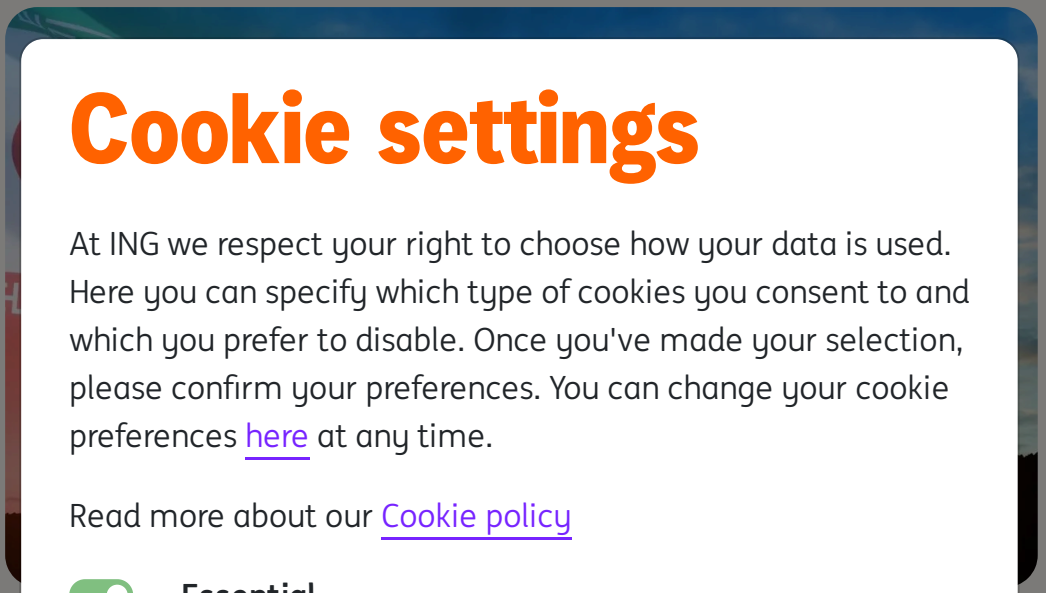
Oil and gas sold off yesterday amid positive signs for US-Iran talks ahead of today's US midterm elections

Warren Patterson and Ewa Manthey



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we've seen this before with nothing materialising, positive signals appear to be coming from both the US and Iran. President Trump responded "no" to a question on whether he would strike Iran following the midterm elections. Iran's president said that the government has been given more authority from the country's supreme leader to negotiate with the US. Despite these positive signals, it's probably too early to think escalation risks have passed. On Monday, the US carried out strikes on Iran's Qeshm Island, reportedly in response to Iran firing at a US aircraft.

What is clear, though, is that strong signals of progress in peace talks would mean more downside for prices. The market still has a

large risk premium baked in, particularly given the strong oil flows from the Persian Gulf.

European gas prices also came under significant pressure on the back of US-Iran hopes, with TTF settling 8.7% lower on the day at a little under EUR95/MWh. For the gas market, de-escalation is crucial, as LNG flows from the region haven't recovered as much as on the oil side. This leaves the market vulnerable as it heads deeper into the European heating season.

Metals - Gold climbs back from one-year low

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US midterms | TTF | Trump | Strait of Hormuz | Persian Gulf | Natural gas | LNG | Iran war | Geopolitics | Brent

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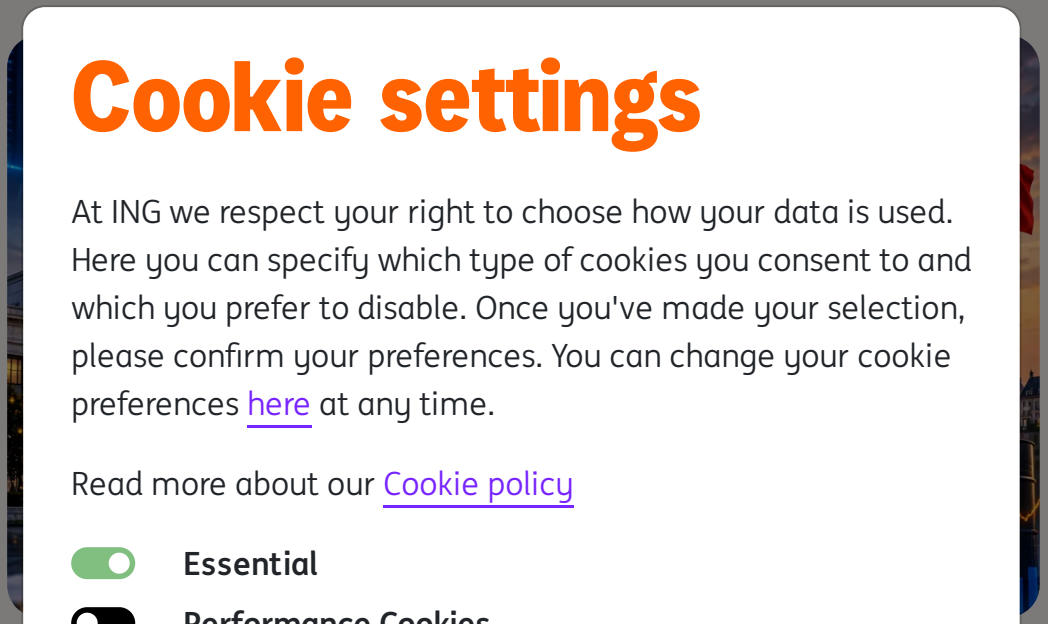
Join ING's economists on 10 November as they share their biggest calls for 2027, plus the risks and surprises that could knock the global economy off course. Sign up here

Carsten Brzeski, James Knightley, James Smith and Rebecca Byrne



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crashing down, taking business investment with it? Can Europe's surprising economic resilience continue, or will dramatic elections, political brinkmanship and rising bond yields herald a return to stagnation?

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Economic outlook

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We expect a 7-2 vote to hike rates this week and, barring a collapse in energy prices, we think a follow-up move in February is likely too. However, market pricing for the Bank of England still looks extreme

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above 4%

The Bank of England has so far managed to avoid a rate hike since the start of the Iran war, but that's about to change. We, like most, expect a hike at its 5 November meeting, and think a follow-up move in February is more likely than not.

Why now? Until now, the Bank would argue it's been on "active hold". It was set to cut rates by upwards of 50 basis points this year, so simply not doing that amounted to de facto tightening. By that logic, the Bank has added a similar amount of policy restriction as the European Central Bank, which has lifted its deposit rate twice.

But the worsening energy crisis has made it much harder for the Bank not to act. The spike in natural gas prices means inflation is set to take another leg higher into winter. A circa 25% rise in the regulated cap on household energy bills in January is all but baked in.

We expect headline CPI to peak a touch above 4% early next year, and we think the BoE's new forecasts will show this too. The Bank's July projections had inflation reaching 3.2% in late 2026, based on oil below US$80/bbl and natural gas at around half its current level.

Energy prices have risen significantly since t

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The Bank is set to hike rates for insurance purposes

4% is an important line in the sand for the BoE. Last summer, the Bank set out research suggesting that second-round effects become more likely once inflation surpasses this level. We suspect this is still front of mind for many officials.

Then again, there is essentially no sign of these much-feared second-round effects so far. Away from motor fuel, inflation has been in line with the Bank's July forecasts. Our measure of 'energy-

intensive' inflation has actually fallen this year, even after accounting for one-off changes in water bills and car tax.

One of the Bank's favoured measures of 'core services' inflation, which strips out volatile and indexed categories, is well-behaved too. And though it has likely bottomed out, private-sector wage growth at 3.4% year-on-year is hardly problematic. Despite signs of stabilisation in the jobs market, there's little evidence wage pressures are set to build.

True, growth has been much better than feared. But then the Bank has often taken a more sceptical view of the GDP numbers,

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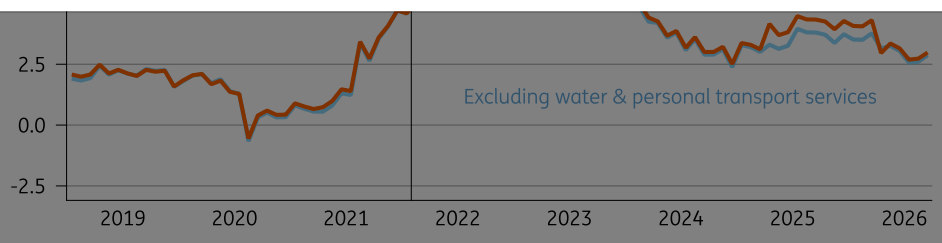

Based on data from the ONS categorising the inflation basket by energy intensity

Source: Macrobond, ING

The key things to watch

So what should we watch at the November meeting?

First, the vote split. We know there are two doves, Swati Dhingra and Alan Taylor, who are deeply sceptical of the need for higher rates. But we suspect the other seven committee members will back a hike. Could there be more dissenters? Governor Andrew Bailey hasn't sounded hugely enthusiastic about hiking, though a governor has only dissented twice since 1997 and both times in the financial crisis.

So if there is extra dissent, Sarah Breeden looks the most likely candidate, having stressed that most businesses are absorbing the energy shock rather than raising prices. Dave Ramsden is another, less likely, candidate.

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rate rises. But it's one thing thinking that, another saying it out loud. There's a lot that can happen between now and February. And having made a hawkish misstep all the way back in March, when the Bank sounded open-minded about tighter policy, opening the floodgates for markets to price in rate hikes, it'll want to tread carefully here.

A more dovish formulation would be if the Bank makes further hikes explicitly contingent on second-round effects: one hike as an insurance move, but anything more requiring solid data. For example, *"If there were evidence of more persistent second-round*

effects in wage and price-setting, further tightening in monetary policy would be required".

Finally, watch the individual member paragraphs tucked away in the minutes. Does anyone formally push back against market pricing, which has more than four hikes priced by this time next year? Even Chief Economist Huw Pill, one of the hawks, has recently indicated that such pricing looks unlikely.

The impact on rates markets

Even if the Bank does choose to push back, will markets listen?

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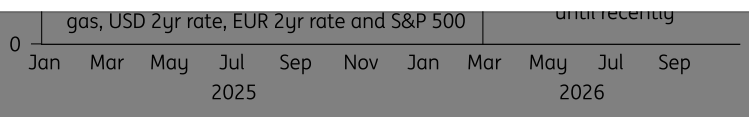
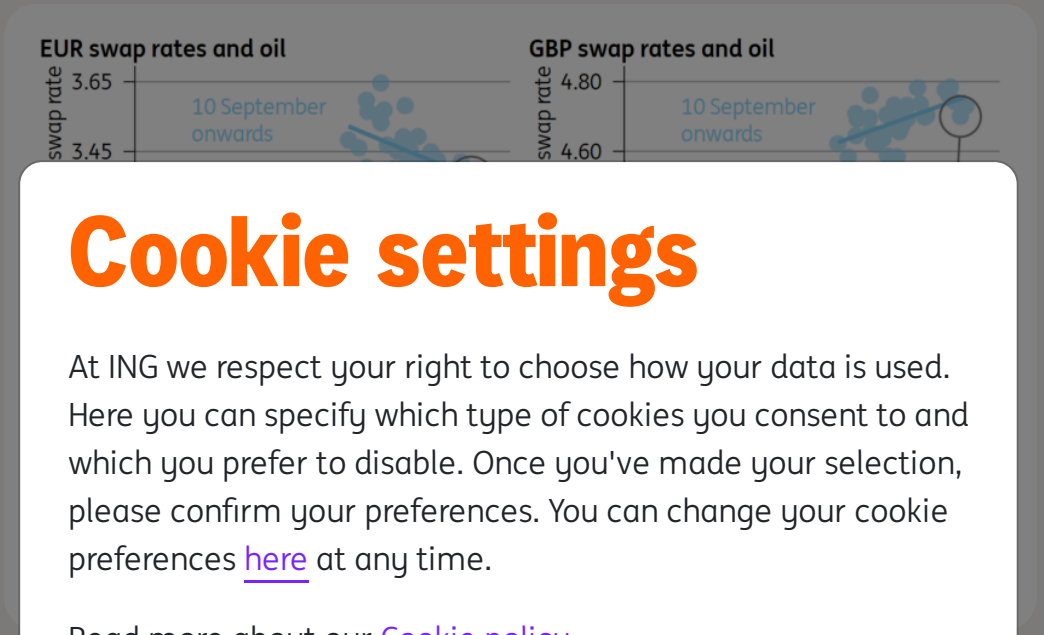


Source: Macrobond, ING

Indeed, the dovish repricing that we've seen for the Federal Reserve and European Central Bank has not been mirrored in the UK. Perhaps it's because Britain lacks a story like France has or, in America's case, AI fears. But robust UK growth data may also be playing a role. Economic surprise indices have been touching multi-year highs.

Still, UK swap rates remain deeply correlated with oil prices. And barring a big surprise, and with more than 100bp of hikes already priced, it's hard to see the Bank triggering a substantial repricing of rate expectations at this meeting.

GBP rates remain positively correlated with oil - unlike EUR rates



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helping sterling too. Notably, speculators are still running reasonably large short positions in sterling, which suggests this period of sterling outperformance can continue.

EUR/GBP has come a long way very quickly – a near 4% drop in a little over a month. Some consolidation is probably due. But with high energy prices likely to keep expectations of higher UK policy rates in place until early next year and French budgetary problems unresolved, it is too early to expect a significant low in EUR/GBP.

United Kingdom GBP Bank of England

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Daling moeilijk vervulbare vacatures

Wervingsproblemen blijven door kwalitatieve mismatch in vraag en aanbod

In het kort

Al langere tijd is de arbeidsmarkt krap en de vraag naar personeel blijft naar verwachting groot in verschillende sectoren.[1] Dit komt door een aanhoudende grote vraag naar personeel, vergrijzing en een teruglopende instroom van nieuwe arbeidskrachten. Hoewel de verwachting is dat de arbeidsmarkt in sommige sectoren ruimer wordt, blijft de krapte in bijvoorbeeld de zorg, onderwijs en voor technische beroepen.[1] Hoe gaan werkgevers met de moeilijk vervulbaar vacatures om?

Deze publicatie kijkt naar de externe werving van nieuw personeel en de problemen die werkgevers daarbij ervaren. Hoe ontwikkelt het aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures? Wat zijn redenen dat vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar zijn? En wat zijn de verwachtingen van werkgevers voor het komende jaar met betrekking tot de vacaturevervulling?

- **Iets minder dan de helft van de in de afgelopen 12 maanden ontstane vacatures (45%) was volgens werkgevers moeilijk vervulbaar**. Dit aandeel was het grootst in de bouw, industrie en overige dienstverlening, cultuur, sport en recreatie.
- Het gemiddelde **aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures is gedaald** ten opzichte van vorige jaren. Deze daling was het grootst bij verhuur en overige zakelijke diensten, financiële instellingen, groothandel en specialistische zakelijke diensten. De bouw was de enige sector waar er sprake was van een stijging van het aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures.
- Werkgevers hebben het **vaakst problemen met de werving voor technische en zorg en welzijn beroepen**. Technische beroepen met veel wervingsproblemen, waren bijvoorbeeld monteurs, lassers/frezers/draaiers en medewerkers in de bouw. Vacatures voor zorg en welzijn beroepen die werkgevers lastig te vervullen vonden, waren bijvoorbeeld voor dokters- /tandarts-/apothekers assistenten, therapeuten, verpleegkundigen, begeleiders en (GZ)psychologen.
- Bijna drie kwart van de werkgevers verwacht dat **komend jaar het vervullen van vacatures niet (nog) moeilijker maar ook niet makkelijker** wordt dan afgelopen jaar. Werkgevers uit de bouw, gezondheidszorg en het onderwijs gaven het vaakst aan dat zij in het komende jaar *meer* wervingsproblemen verwachten. In de informatie en communicatie sector wordt voor komend jaar de *minste* moeite met personeelswerving verwacht.
- Veel genoemde **redenen** voor wervingsproblemen zijn een **gebrek aan reacties** (kwantitatieve krapte), sollicitanten die **niet voldoen aan de functie-eisen** (kwalitatieve mismatch) en de **specialistische aard** van het werk. Mogelijk kan breder werven van personeel voor een deel van de moeilijk vervulbare vacatures een oplossing bieden, bijvoorbeeld door het loslaten van een deel van de functie-eisen en het zelf opleiden van nieuw personeel.
- Volgens ruim een derde van de werkgevers met wervingsproblemen zijn vacatures ook **moeilijk vervulbaar vanwege salariswensen van sollicitanten** waar zij niet aan tegemoet kunnen komen. Dit geldt met name bij de informatie & communicatie (44%) en specialistisch zakelijke dienstverlening (42%). Daarnaast geeft ongeveer 1 op de 5 werkgevers met wervingsproblemen aan dat ze sollicitanten niet tegemoet konden komen in de **werktijden en roosters**, beschikbaarheid of flexibiliteit hierin of in **minder werkuren dan de vacature vraagt**.

Over de publicatie

Dit zijn enkele resultaten van een enquêteonderzoek in opdracht van UWV onder 3.551 werkgevers[2] in het najaar van 2025 (zie de methodebeschrijving in bijlage 2). De enquête had betrekking op werkgevers in bijna alle sectoren [3] en de onderzoeksresultaten zijn representatief voor Nederlandse werkgevers in deze sectoren. In deze publicatie worden ook sectorale verschillen belicht.

[1] Bakens, J., Dijksman, S., Fouarge, D., van Guilik, N., Höfelmann, L., Meijer, R., Pestel, N. (2025). *De arbeidsmarkt naar opleiding en beroep tot 2030*. Maastricht: Researchcentrum voor Onderwijs en Arbeidsmarkt (ROA).
[2] Feitelijk gaat het om vestigingen van bedrijven en instellingen. Voor de leesbaarheid spreken we in dit artikel over 'werkgevers'.
[3] De sectoren 'Landbouw, bosbouw en visserij' en 'Arbeidsbemiddeling, uitzendbureaus en personeel' zijn buiten beschouwing gelaten.

Aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures neemt af

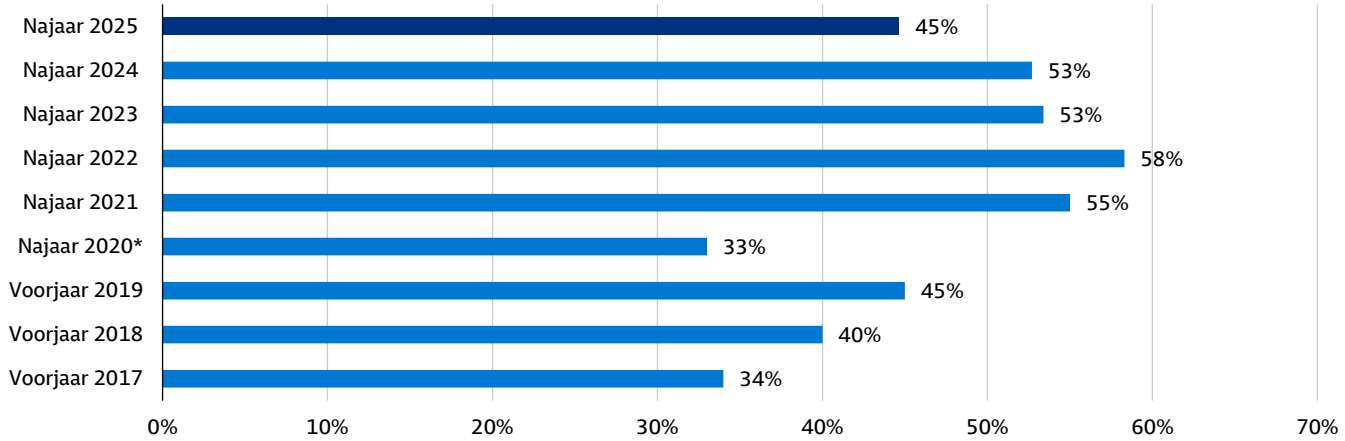
Bijna twee derde van de werkgevers (63%) gaf aan dat ze in de afgelopen 12 maanden een vacature hadden, waarvoor ze buiten de organisatie personeel hebben geworven. Wanneer ze personeel werven gaat het in twee derde van de gevallen (66%) om 1 tot 5 vacatures per vestiging. Bijna 4 op de 10 werkgevers (37%) geeft aan dat zij één of meerdere vacatures moeilijk konden vervullen. Als er sprake was van een problematische werving, ging het in de helft van de gevallen om 1 tot 2 moeilijk vervulbare vacatures.

Het aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures hangt samen met de krapte op de arbeidsmarkt. Tussen 2021 en begin 2025 waren er meer vacatures dan werklozen, dit verschil bereikte in 2022 een piek. Vanaf deze piek wordt de verhouding tussen het aantal vacatures en werklozen kleiner en vanaf 2025 zijn er weer meer werklozen dan vacatures.[4] Daarnaast steeg in 2025 de WW met ruim 9% ten opzichte van eind 2024. [5]

Figuur 1 laat de ontwikkeling van het gemiddelde aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures bij werkgevers zien. Sinds de piek in 2022 neemt het aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures weer af. Desalniettemin blijft gemiddeld genomen **iets minder dan de helft van de vacatures volgens de werkgevers moeilijk vervulbaar.**[6] Het gaat daarbij om de inschatting van de werkgever zelf dat de vacature moeilijk vervulbaar was. Het gemiddelde aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures is **gedaald ten opzichte van vorige jaren**. In 2024 en 2023 was dit nog 53%. Daarmee is het op hetzelfde niveau als voor de coronacrisis, in het voorjaar van 2019.

Figuur 1. Ontwikkeling gemiddeld aandeel ontstane vacatures dat moeilijk vervulbaar is

Respondenten is gevraagd naar vacatures in de afgelopen 12 maanden.
2017-2025, gebaseerd op meerdere enquêtes van UWV



* In het onderzoek van 2020 ging het om vacatures die waren ontstaan sinds half maart tot het moment van enquêtering: september tot half november 2020. In de overige enquêtes ging het om vacatures die in een periode van een jaar waren ontstaan.
Bron: UWV

Aan de werkgevers is in een open vraag gevraagd voor welke functie binnen hun vestiging vacatures het moeilijkst vervulbaar te vervullen zijn. Het zijn vooral de technische beroepen (27%) die genoemd worden zoals monteurs, lassers/frezers/draaiers en medewerkers in de bouw. Gevolgd door zorg en welzijn beroepen (14%) zoals dokters- /tandarts- /apothekers assistenten, therapeuten, verpleegkundigen, begeleiders en (GZ)psychologen.

Tabel 1. Top 6 van beroepen waarvoor vacatures volgens werkgevers het moeilijkst vervulbaar zijn

Beroepsrichting	% werkgevers dat beroep in deze beroepsklasse noemde	Voorbeelden van veel genoemde beroepen met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures
Technisch	27%	Monteurs, CNC operators/verspaners/ lassers/frezers/draaiers, medewerkers bouw zoals timmerlieden, metselaars en schilders en engineers/projectleiders
Zorg en welzijn	13%	Dokters/tandarts/apothekers assistenten, therapeuten, verpleegkundigen, (persoonlijk/ ambulant/ woon) begeleiders, (GZ)psychologen
Economisch-administratief	11%	Werkvoorbereiders/ calculators, financieel-administratief medewerkers, financieel adviseurs en accountants
Commercieel	10%	Verkopers, verzekeringsadviseurs, acceptanten en inkopers
Dienstverlenend	10%	Kappers/haarstylisten, koks en schoonmakers
Pedagogisch	8%	Leraren primair en voortgezet onderwijs en pedagogisch medewerker kinderopvang/bso

Bron: UWV

[4] CBS (2026) *Dashboard Arbeidsmarkt: Spanning op de arbeidsmarkt.* Geraadpleegd op 27 januari 2026.
[5] UWV (2026) *Nieuwsflits: aantal WW-uitkeringen afgenomen in december* .
[6] Het gaat om het gemiddelde aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures. Er is eerst aan de respondenten gevraagd *hoeveel* vacatures zij in de afgelopen 12 maanden hadden, vervolgens is gevraagd *hoeveel* vacatures hiervan moeilijk vervulbaar waren. Op basis van deze informatie is *per werkgever* een aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures berekend, waarmee vervolgens het *gemiddelde* aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures is berekend.

Nog steeds meeste moeilijk vervulbare vacatures in de bouw

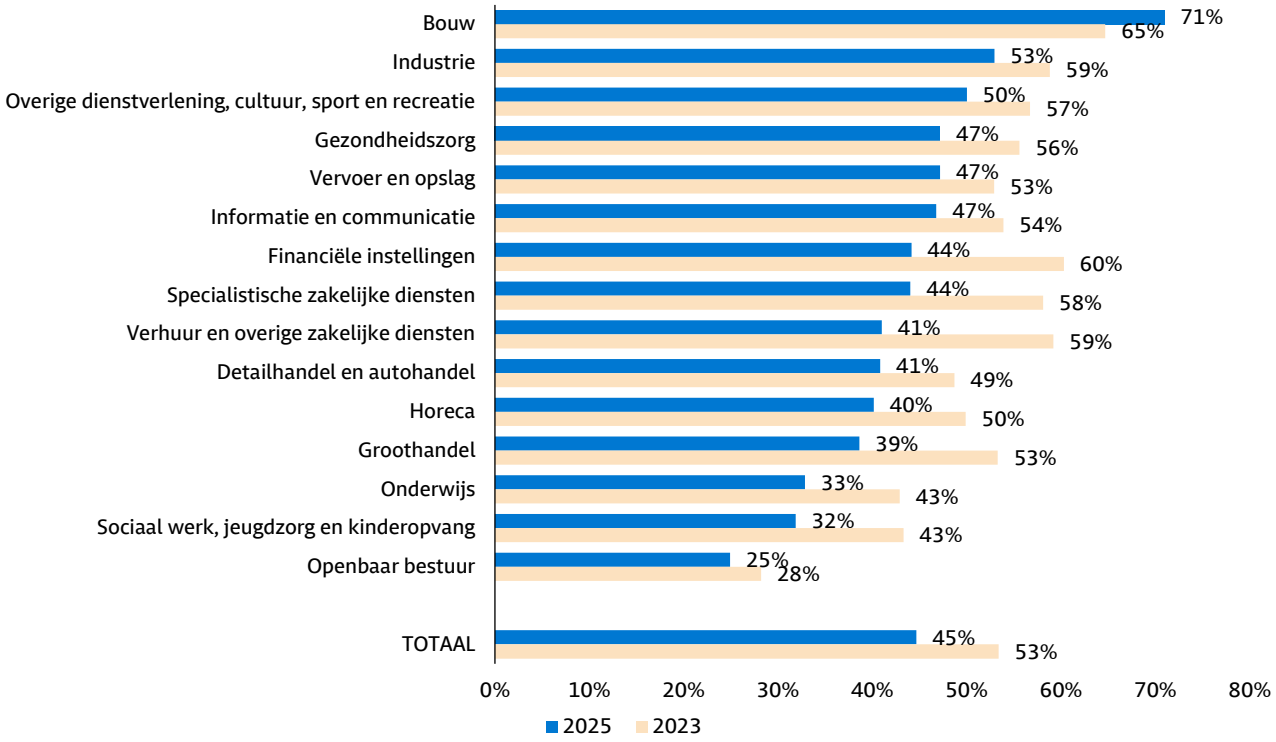
Zoals eerder beschreven daalde het gemiddelde aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures van 53% in 2023 naar 45% in 2025 (figuur 1). Voor sommige sectoren is de **daling in moeilijk vervulbare vacatures** nog sterker, zoals **bij verhuur en overige zakelijke diensten**, **financiële instellingen**, **groothandel** en **specialistische zakelijke diensten** (figuur 2).

Net als in UWV-onderzoek[7] uit 2023 zijn volgens werkgevers **vacatures in de bouw het vaakst moeilijk vervulbaar.** De bouw is de enige sector waar het aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures is gestegen (van 65% naar 71%) en steekt daarmee boven de andere sectoren uit. Gezien de vacaturegraad in de bouw momenteel al hoog is[8] en een verdere groei in de bouwprojecten wordt verwacht[9] zal de personeelskrapte in de bouw een aandachtspunt blijven. Hoewel in de bouw momenteel de personeelstekorten niet als de grootste belemmering in de bedrijfsvoering wordt gezien,[10] ervaren werkgevers vacatures wel vaak als moeilijk vervulbaar en nam dit gevoel afgelopen jaar toe. Tabel 2 laat per sector de beroepen zien waarbij werkgevers de meeste moeite hebben om nieuw personeel te werven. Volgens de respondenten in de bouw is het verkrijgen van voldoende medewerkers voor de bouwplaats, monteurs maar ook werkvoorbereiders, calculators het lastigste.

De bouw wordt gevolgd door de **industrie** (53%). Beroepen waarvoor werkgevers wervingsproblemen ervaren, zijn bijvoorbeeld machine/service/ elektro monteurs, CNC operators/verspaners, productiemedewerkers. Ook in de **overige dienstverlening, cultuur, sport en recreatie** is gemiddeld de helft van de vacatures lastig te vervullen. Veelgenoemde beroepen met grote wervingsproblemen zijn hier bijvoorbeeld kapper of haarstylist en sportinstructeur.

Figuur 2. Gemiddeld aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures naar sector

Najaar 2023 en najaar 2025



Bron: UWV

Tabel 2. Beroepen met de meeste wervingsproblemen, per sector

Sector	Voorbeelden van veel genoemde beroepen met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures
Bouw	Medewerkers bouwplaats (zoals timmerlieden, metselaars), monteurs, werkvoorbereiders en calculators
Industrie	Machine/service/ electro monteurs, CNC operators/verspaners, productiemedewerkers
Overige dienstverlening, cultuur, sport en recreatie	Kappers/ haarstylisten, sportinstructeurs

[7] UWV (2024) *Ruim de helft van de vacatures nog moeilijk vervulbaar*
[8] CBS (2026) *Vacaturegraad naar bedrijfstak*. Geraadpleegd op 6 februari 2026.
[9] Economisch Instituut voor de Bouw (2026) *Persbericht verwachtingen 2026*
[10] CBS (2026) *COEN enquête eerste kwartaal 2026.*

Gezondheidszorg	Dokters/tandarts/apothekers assistenten, therapeuten (zoals huid-, fysio-), verpleegkundigen, (persoonlijk/ ambulant/ woon) begeleiders en (GZ)psychologen
Vervoer en opslag	Chauffeurs, monteurs, kapitein/schippers/matrozen, financieel-administratief medewerkers
Informatie en communicatie	Software developers, -consultants, IT engineers, SEO specialisten/marketeers,
Financiële instellingen	Adviseurs en acceptanten voor verzekeringen/hypotheken, schade experts en financieel adviseurs
Specialistische zakelijke diensten	(assistent) accountants, controllers, engineers, civiele techniek, juristen en software ontwikkelaars
Verhuur en overige zakelijke diensten	Schoonmakers/ glazenwassers, beveiligers, financieel-administratieve medewerkers
Detailhandel en autohandel	Verkopers, autoschadeherstellers en -monteurs
Horeca	Bediening, (zelfstandig werkende) koks of chefkoks
Groothandel	Verkopers, (machine) monteurs financieel-administratief medewerkers
Onderwijs	Leraren primair onderwijs, leraren voortgezet onderwijs (met name talen en exacte vakken)
Sociaal werk, jeugdzorg en kinderopvang	Pedagogisch medewerkers kinderopvang, pedagogisch professionals, sociaal werkers (begeleiders, jeugdzorgwerker, maatschappelijk werker)
Openbaar bestuur	Juristen/juridisch adviseurs, beleidsmedewerkers/-adviseurs en planologen/ ingenieurs

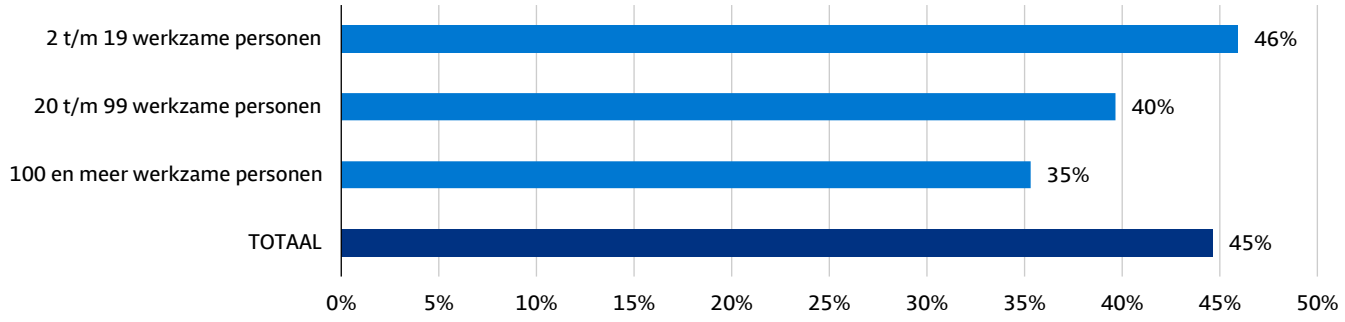
Deze tabel geeft alleen weer wat per sector de meest genoemde beroepen zijn met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures. Het zegt niet iets over de verhouding tussen de beroepen of sectoren: In figuur 2 is bijvoorbeeld te zien dat het gemiddelde aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures tussen de sectoren verschilt. Ook zegt tabel 2 niets over de baankansen voor werkzoekenden.
Bron: UWV

Meeste wervingsproblemen bij kleinere werkgevers

Kleinere werkgevers ervaren gemiddeld een groter deel van de vacatures als moeilijk vervulbaar dan werkgevers met 100 werknemers of meer (figuur 3).

Dit beeld komt overeen met UWV-onderzoek uit eerdere jaren. Het zou te maken kunnen hebben met de grotere omvang van de HR-afdeling en het grotere budget voor werving bij werkgevers met 100 of meer werkzame personen. Ook kan het zijn dat grotere werkgevers aantrekkelijker zijn voor werkzoekenden doordat zij meer loopbaan- of doorgroeimogelijkheden kunnen bieden. Daarnaast zullen bij grote werkgevers vacatures vaker intern vervuld kunnen worden. Ten slotte zou kunnen meespelen dat bij grote werkgevers de vragenlijst vaak is ingevuld door medewerkers van HR-afdelingen[11] en bij kleine werkgevers vaak door directeuren/eigenaren. Mogelijk beoordelen HR-medewerkers bij grote werkgevers het al dan niet moeilijk vervulbaar zijn van een vacature anders dan directeuren bij kleine werkgevers.

Figuur 3. Gemiddeld aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures naar omvang



Bron: UWV

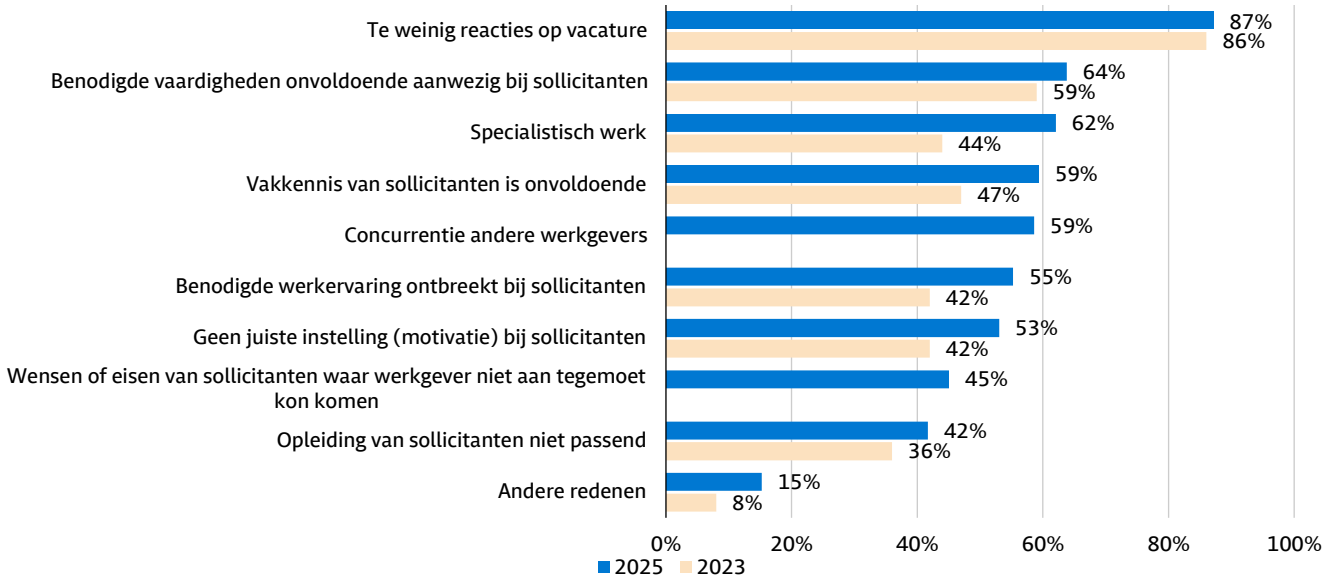
Moeilijk vervulbare vacatures vooral door weinig reacties en vaardigheden

Bijna alle werkgevers met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures (87%) geven aan dat een gebrek aan reacties de reden was dat vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar waren (figuur 4). Dit aandeel is nagenoeg gelijk gebleven ten opzichte van 2023. Mogelijk komen er minder reacties omdat de passende werkzoekenden de vacature niet kunnen vinden of doordat ze op basis van de vacaturetekst denken dat de baan niet past bij hun interesse of vaardigheden. Uit UWV onderzoek onder 4.200 *werkzoekenden*[12] blijkt dat een groot deel moeite ervaart om geschikte vacatures te vinden die passen bij hun interesse of behoefte en dat zij hier graag hulp bij willen.[13]

[11] Of personeelszaken / personeel & organisatie
[12] UWV (2025) *Het zoekgedrag van werkzoekenden: inzichten voor gerichte werving en selectie*
[13] UWV (2026) *Het zoekgedrag van werkzoekenden: drempels en hulpvragen van werkzoekenden in de zoektocht naar werk*

Figuur 4. Redenen waarom vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar waren

Aandeel werkgevers met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures dat de reden noemt (meerdere redenen mogelijk)



* In 2023 is niet gevraagd of vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar waren vanwege concurrentie van andere werkgevers en niet of er wensen of eisen van sollicitanten waren waar de werkgever niet aan tegemoet kon komen. Daarom ontbreekt voor deze antwoordopties in deze figuur de percentages voor 2023.
** Als andere redenen waarom vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar waren (open vraag) noemen werkgevers regelmatig de arbeidsmarktkrapte, aard van het werk, het aantal uren of de werktijden, dat de sollicitanten niet passen binnen het team of niet de juiste instelling hebben of de taal.
Bron: UWV

Naast te weinig reacties, blijkt uit figuur 4 ook dat werkgevers **een kwalitatieve mismatch** ervaren. Volgens werkgevers zijn vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar omdat sollicitanten niet over de benodigde vaardigheden beschikten (64%), onvoldoende vakkennis hadden (59%) of niet over de benodigde werkervaring beschikten (55%). Ongeveer 6 op 10 werkgevers geeft aan het specialistische karakter van het werk een reden is waarom het lastig is om nieuw personeel te vinden. Opvallend is dat werkgevers vaker aangeven dat kandidaten niet de juiste vaardigheden hebben dan dat ze aangeven dat de kandidaat onvoldoende werkervaring, niet de juiste vakkennis of geen passende opleiding heeft. Werkgevers lijken vaardigheden dan ook belangrijker te vinden dan de juiste kennis, ervaring of opleiding.

Voor werkzoekenden met een WW-uitkering blijkt het niet voldoen aan de formele vacature eisen vaak de grootste drempel te vormen om werk te vinden, zoals het ontbreken van de gewenste diploma's of certificaten (23%) en het niet hebben van de gewenste werkervaring (19%).[14] Zowel werkgevers als werkzoekenden hebben te maken met een mismatch tussen wat in de vacature gevraagd wordt aan diploma's, vakkennis en werkervaring en wat geïnteresseerde werkzoekenden kunnen bieden. Dit wijst op het belang van skills-based werving en om meer te focussen op wat de kandidaat kan en wat voor vaardigheden die heeft. Het inzetten van (bij)scholing is mogelijk om vakkennis bij te spijkeren of om diploma's of certificaten alsnog te halen. Werkgevers én werkzoekenden zijn hiertoe bereid, blijkt uit onderzoek van UWV. [14, 15]

Werkgevers én werkzoekenden bereid om te investeren in scholing voor een functie

De helft van de werkgevers die in de afgelopen 12 maanden een vacature hadden, geeft aan vanwege de krapte vaker kandidaten aan te nemen die nog opgeleid moeten worden (52%). Een deel van de werkgevers zegt ook vanwege de krapte vaker takenpakketten van vacatures aan te passen (20%) en functie-eisen van vacatures te verlagen of schrappen (17%).[16]

Scholing speelt een cruciale factor in het aannemen van kandidaten die niet aan alle functie-eisen voldoen. Uit UWV-onderzoek onder 4.200 werkzoekenden blijkt dat ook werkzoekenden hiertoe bereid zijn. Zo zeggen werkzoekenden het vaakst dat ze - om de kansen op een baan te vergroten- bereid zijn om scholing te volgen naast hun nieuwe baan.[17] Daarnaast staat informatie over scholing of trainingen in de top drie van zaken waar werkzoekenden met een WW-uitkering behoefte aan hebben.[14]

De *kwalitatieve mismatch* wordt vaker genoemd door werkgevers in het **openbaar bestuur**, bij **informatie en communicatie** en bij **financiële instellingen**. In deze sectoren benoemen werkgevers vaker dan in andere sectoren dat kandidaten niet voldoen aan vaardigheden, vakkennis, werkervaring of passende opleiding (tabel 3 in bijlage). Mogelijk zijn werkzoekenden in deze sectoren eerder geneigd te solliciteren als zij niet helemaal aan de functie-eisen voldoen of stellen werkgevers hogere eisen dan in andere sectoren. Dat vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar zijn doordat de kandidaat geen passende opleiding heeft wordt ook door werkgevers in

[14] UWV (2026) *Het zoekgedrag van werkzoekenden: drempels en hulpvragen van werkzoekenden in de zoektocht naar werk*
[15] UWV (2025) *Werkgeversonderzoek 2024: Loslaten van functie-eisen bij werving*
[16] UWV (2026) *Krapte op de arbeidsmarkt: wat werkgevers doen om personeel te werven*
[17] UWV (2025) *Het zoekgedrag van werkzoekenden: inzichten voor gerichte werving en selectie*

de gezondheidszorg en sociaal werk, jeugdzorg en kinderopvang genoemd. Deze sectoren hebben ook te maken met wettelijke opleidingseisen. Kwalitatieve mismatch wordt juist *minder* vaak genoemd als reden voor de wervingsproblemen in de gezondheidszorg, verhuur en overige zakelijke dienstverlening. Hier noemen werkgevers minder vaak dan in andere sectoren dat sollicitanten niet de juiste vaardigheden, vakkennis of werkervaring hebben.

Ruim de helft van de werkgevers geeft aan dat de vacaturevervulling lastig is omdat ze **concurrentie van andere werkgevers ervaren**. Dit speelt met name in de specialistische zakelijke dienstverlening, waar het merendeel van de werkgevers (82%) dit benoemt. Daarnaast geeft bijna de helft van de werkgevers aan **dat sollicitanten wensen of eisen hebben** waar zij als werkgever niet aan tegemoet konden komen. Hier wordt verderop in deze publicatie nader op ingegaan.

In figuur 2 was te zien dat het aandeel moeilijk vervulbare vacatures daalde in de periode 2023-2025. Maar in figuur 4 is te zien dat voor nagenoeg alle redenen voor de wervingsproblemen,[18] het aandeel werkgevers is toegenomen. Indien er sprake was van wervingsproblemen, ervaren werkgevers nagenoeg even vaak als in 2023 een tekort aan reacties op de vacature. Er is dus even vaak sprake van een kwantitatieve mismatch tussen de vraag van de werkgever en het aanbod van werkzoekenden. Daarnaast is vaker (ook) sprake van een kwalitatieve mismatch. Werkgevers benoemen in 2025 vaker dan in 2023 dat het lastig was om personeel voor de vacature te vinden omdat bijvoorbeeld de benodigde werkervaring of vakkennis bij sollicitanten onvoldoende was.

Salariswens bij ruim een derde mede oorzaak moeilijk vervulbare vacatures

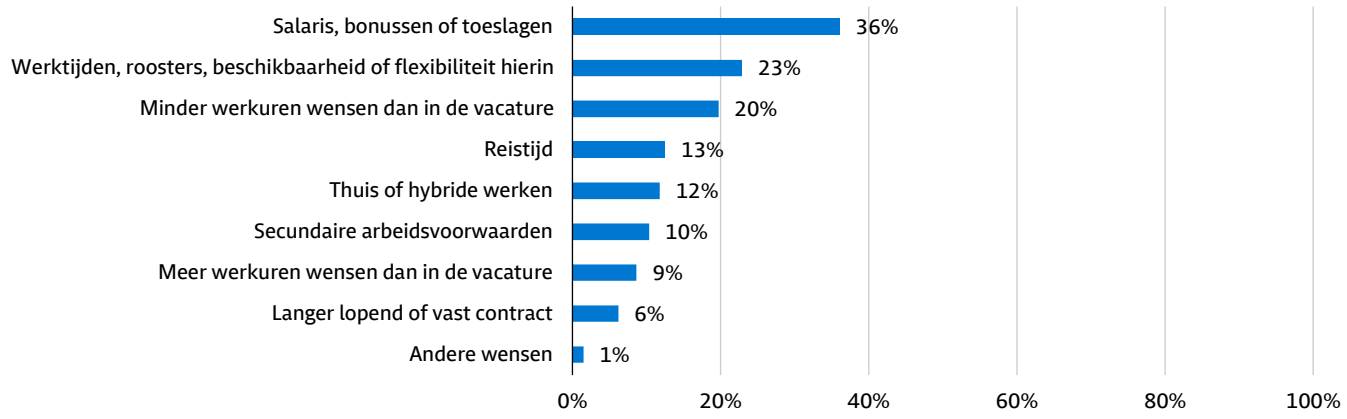
Wanneer er sprake is van moeilijk vervulbare vacatures, dan geeft bijna de helft (45%) van de werkgevers aan dat dit mede kwam doordat de sollicitant wensen of eisen hadden waar de werkgever niet aan tegemoet kon komen (figuur 4). Figuur 5 laat zien aan *welke* wensen of eisen van sollicitanten werkgevers niet tegemoet konden komen. Wensen rondom **salaris, bonussen of toeslagen** zorgden volgens een derde van de werkgevers mede voor de wervingsproblemen. Dit aandeel is het hoogst bij de **informatie & communicatie** en **specialistisch zakelijke dienstverlening**. Van de groep werkgevers die kampt met salariseisen van werkzoekenden geeft 47% aan vanwege de krapte op de arbeidsmarkt betere arbeidsvoorwaarden te bieden. Mogelijk hebben ze vanwege de salariseisen van sollicitanten toch opnieuw gekeken naar hun arbeidsvoorwaarden.

Na het salaris, benoemen werkgevers ook dat ze in zaken rondom de werk-privé balans de sollicitant niet tegemoet konden komen: Ongeveer 1 op de 5 werkgevers met moeilijke te vervullen vacatures geeft aan dat ze sollicitanten niet tegemoet konden komen in de **werktijden, roosters, beschikbaarheid of flexibiliteit hierin** (23%) of in de wens van **minder werkuren** dan in de vacature (20%). Ook de wensen over de reistijd (13%) of thuis/hybride werken (12%) werden genoemd als reden dat één of meerdere vacature moeilijk vervulbaar waren.

Dat werkzoekenden belang hechten aan de financiële vergoeding en de werk-privé balans blijkt ook uit eerder UWV onderzoek.[19] Het salaris is door werkzoekenden het vaakst genoemd als wat ze belangrijk vinden in een baan (40% bij werkzoekenden met WW en 46% bij overige werkzoekenden), hoewel het niet de meest genoemde 'dealbreaker' is om een aangeboden baan te weigeren: dat zijn een onprettige werksfeer of te lange reistijd. Een derde van de werkzoekenden met een WW-uitkering (33%) en een op de zeven werkzoekenden zonder WW (14%) is wel bereid om concessies te doen op het gebied van salaris. Deze flexibiliteit neemt verder toe naarmate zij langer op zoek zijn naar werk. Daarnaast zijn werkzoekenden met een hbo- of wo diploma vaker bereid tot concessies dan werkzoekenden met een ander opleidingsniveau.

Figuur 5. Wensen of eisen van sollicitant waar de werkgever niet aan tegemoet kon komen

Aandeel werkgevers met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures dat de betreffende wens of eis van sollicitant noemt (meerdere antwoorden mogelijk)



* Als andere wensen (open vraag) noemen werkgevers bijvoorbeeld de aard van het werk, de behoefte om het werk als zzp'er te willen doen, de reiskosten of bereikbaarheid.
Bron: UWV

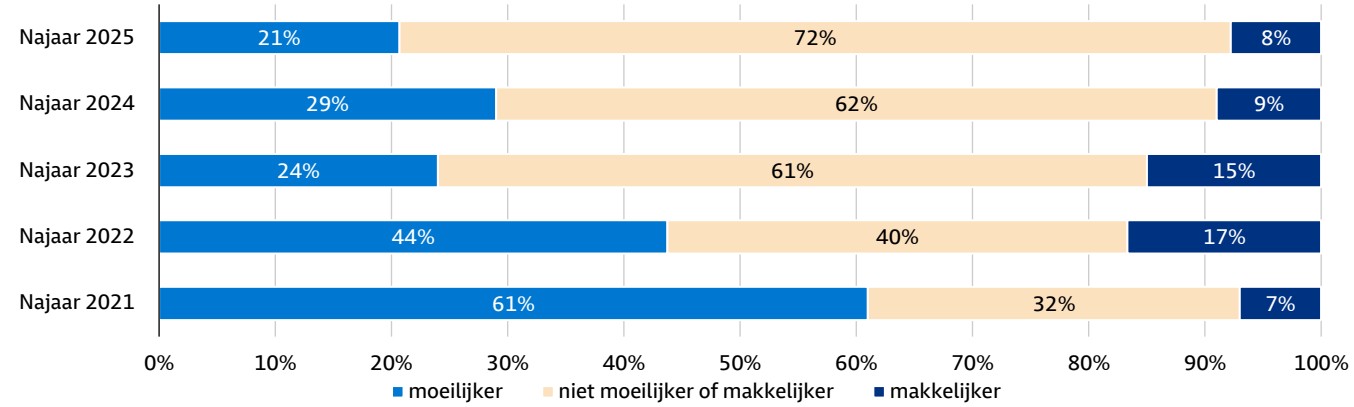
[18] In 2023 is niet aan de werkgevers gevraagd of vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar waren doordat er concurrentie van andere werkgevers was of omdat de werknemer wensen had waar de werkgever niet aan kon voldoen.
[19] UWV (2025) *Het zoekgedrag van werkzoekenden: inzichten voor gerichte werving en selectie*

Weinig verandering in wervingsproblemen verwacht

In het najaar van 2025 verwacht **bijna driekwart (72%) van de werkgevers dat de vacaturevervulling in 2026 niet moeilijker of makkelijker** zal worden (figuur 6). Deze groep is gegroeid ten opzichte van vorig jaar, toen dacht 62% van de werkgevers dat het niet moeilijker of makkelijker werd.

Daarnaast verwacht 21% van de werkgevers dat het vervullen van vacatures (nog) moeilijker wordt. Daarmee is het aandeel werkgevers dat verwacht dat de wervingsproblemen toenemen kleiner geworden, vorig jaar was dit 29%. Net als vorig jaar verwachten nog steeds weinig werkgevers (8%) dat het werven makkelijker gaat worden.

Figuur 6. Verwachting dat het vervullen van vacatures in volgende jaar moeilijker of makkelijker wordt
Aandeel werkgevers 2021-2025



Bron: UWV

De verwachting over de vacaturevervulling verschilt per sector (zie bijlage). Het aandeel werkgevers dat verwacht dat de wervingsproblemen komend jaar toenemen is het grootst in de **bouw** (27%), **gezondheidszorg** (26%), het **onderwijs** (25%).

In totaal verwacht 8% van de werkgevers dat de vacaturevervulling in 2026 makkelijker gaat worden dan in 2025. Dit aandeel ligt hoger in de **informatie & communicatie** waar 1 op de 5 werkgevers **verwacht dat de vacaturevervulling komend jaar makkelijker wordt**. Hoewel er lange tijd sprake was van een krappe arbeidsmarkt voor IT beroepen, neemt deze krapte af.[20] Ook uit cijfers van CBS[21] blijkt dat de Informatie & communicatie sector geen overmatig last van personeelstekorten heeft. Het aandeel werkgevers uit deze sector dat aangeeft een tekort aan arbeidskrachten als een belemmering te zien is gedaald van 53% in juli 2022 naar 29% in juli 2025. Landelijk (exclusief publieke sector, financiële- en nutsbedrijven) was dit in juli volgens het CBS 36%.[20] Dit kan te maken hebben met de toegenomen arbeidsproductiviteit in de sector, meer reorganisaties vanwege AI en een toename van faillissementen in andere sectoren waar veel ICT'ers werken. [20]

Er is nagenoeg geen verschil naar vestigingsomvang in de verwachtingen over de vervulbaarheid van vacatures. Werkgevers van vestigingen met meer of minder dan 100 personeelsleden, hebben ongeveer dezelfde verwachtingen.

Tot slot: handvatten voor werkzoekenden en werkgevers

In deze publicatie komt naar voren dat ondanks de afkoelende arbeidsmarkt nog altijd 45% van de vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar is, met name in de bouw. Slechts een klein deel van de werkgevers verwacht dat het volgend jaar gemakkelijker wordt om personeel te vinden.

De wervingsproblemen komen volgens werkgevers vooral door een gebrek aan reacties (kwantitatieve mismatch), in iets mindere mate doordat sollicitanten niet voldoen aan de functie-eisen (kwalitatieve mismatch) en daarnaast de specialistische aard van het werk. Volgens 36% van de werkgevers zijn vacatures ook moeilijk vervulbaar omdat sollicitanten salariswensen hebben waar zij niet aan tegemoet kunnen komen. Dit geldt vooral in informatie & communicatie en de specialistische zakelijke dienstverlening. De kwalitatieve mismatch komt niet alleen in deze publicatie naar voren, ook onderzoek onder werkzoekenden laat zien dat werkzoekenden het gebrek aan de gevraagde diploma's of werkervaring benoemen als een belemmering om een baan te vinden. Zowel werkgevers als werkzoekenden hebben te maken met een mismatch tussen wat in de vacature gevraagd wordt en wat geïnteresseerde werkzoekenden kunnen bieden. Maar ook andersom, er is ook een mismatch in wat werkzoekenden zoeken en wat werkgevers kunnen en willen bieden, bijvoorbeeld op het gebied van arbeidsvoorwaarden.

Dit onderstreept het belang om te blijven kijken naar wat de kandidaat kan, in plaats van enkel te kijken naar diploma's of directe werkervaring. Dit gebeurt ook al veel in de praktijk, blijkt uit eerder UWV onderzoek.[22] Bijscholing kan een oplossing bieden en werkzoekenden geven aan dat ze bereid zijn om te leren.

[20] UWV (2025) *Arbeidskrapte ICT'ers neemt af, maar is nog altijd groot*
[21] CBS (2025) *Conjunctuurenquête Nederland.* Geraadpleegd op 2 februari 2026.
[22] UWV (2025) *Werkgeversonderzoek 2024: Loslaten van functie-eisen bij werving*

Voor **werkzoekenden** biedt het Regionaal werkcentrum (RWC) **loopbaanadvies en informatie over scholing**. Een overzicht van regelingen voor scholing, ontwikkeling en financiering staat bijvoorbeeld op de website Leeroverzicht.nl.[23] Via UWV zijn er verschillende paden en regelingen om deel te nemen aan of advies te krijgen over scholing. Denk hierbij aan scholing vanuit een uitkering,[24] scholing via het RWC.[25] In bepaalde situaties kan UWV ondersteunen bij de bekostiging van de opleiding:[26] De scholing dient noodzakelijk te zijn om weer duurzaam aan het werk te gaan in het beoogde voor de werkzoekende passende bemiddelingsberoep én het is aannemelijk dat de werkzoekende deze scholing met succes zal kunnen afronden.[27]

Werkgevers kunnen terecht bij één van de **WerkgeversServicepunten** voor **advies en ondersteuning bij werving**. Er is het Landelijk WerkgeversServicepunt en er zijn 35 regionale WerkgeversServicepunten. Ook kunnen zij werkgevers die last hebben van de krapte op de arbeidsmarkt advies geven over scholing van werknemers, werving op basis van skills en over het anders organiseren van het werk.

Wanneer vacatures lastig te vervullen zijn omdat er te weinig geschikte kandidaten reageren en/of kandidaten niet de gevraagde vaardigheden of diploma's hebben, kan het nodig zijn om breder te werven. Daarbij kan het nuttig zijn om kritisch te kijken naar de manier van werven. Zijn alle gevraagde vaardigheden echt nodig? Het **breder werven van nieuw personeel** is één de drie pijlers in de UWV publicatie '**34 oplossingen voor personeelstekorten**'. Hierbij gaat het niet zozeer om meer wervingskanalen te benutten, maar om onder een breder publiek te werven. Bijvoorbeeld werkzoekenden uit ander sectoren, statushouders, mensen met een arbeidsbeperking, stagiairs of gepensioneerden. Deze zijn niet altijd direct inzetbaar, maar soms wel met scholing en wat extra ondersteuning.

In de publicatie over 34 oplossingen voor personeelstekorten worden toepasbare praktijkvoorbeelden van breder werven gegeven. Het gaat bijvoorbeeld om:[28]

- Mensen laagdrempelig laten kennismaken met de organisatie
- Functie-eisen loslaten
- Focussen op skills
- Openstaan voor 55 plussers
- Open hiring
- Talent binnen eigen organisatie benutten
- Nieuw personeel zelf opleiden

Daarnaast heeft UWV handouts voor werkgevers ontwikkeld met **oplossingen voor personeelstekorten bij 14 beroepsgroepen**.[29] Het gaat om praktijkvoorbeelden van oplossingen die al worden toegepast door werkgevers of kansrijk zijn.

Bevindingen uit het UWV Werkzoekendenonderzoek bieden concrete handvatten voor het wervingsproces

Uit UWV onderzoek onder 4.200 werkzoekenden[30] blijkt dat

- De inzet van meerdere, doelgroepgerichte wervingskanalen essentieel is: een algemene aanpak volstaat niet.
- Werkzoekenden volledigheid en duidelijkheid verwachten in vacatures. Zo wordt voorkomen dat werkzoekende en werkgever tijd investeren in een sollicitatieprocedure waarbij de vacature uiteindelijk niet relevant blijkt voor de werkzoekende.
- Belangrijk hierbij is de communicatie over de arbeidsvoorwaarden, want de keuze voor een baan wordt bepaald door een combinatie van factoren: een passend salaris, een goede werksfeer en een goede werk-privébalans. Deze factoren zijn niet alleen de belangrijkste wensen, ze vormen ook de grootste 'dealbreakers'.

Deze en andere uitkomsten zijn te lezen in de twee artikelen gebaseerd op het werkzoekendenonderzoek:

- Het zoekgedrag van werkzoekenden: inzichten voor gerichte werving en selectie
- Het zoekgedrag van werkzoekenden: Drempels en hulpvragen van werkzoekenden in de zoektocht naar werk

[23] https://www.leeroverzicht.nl/
[24] https://www.uwv.nl/nl/opleiding
[25] https://werkcentrum.nl/
[26] UWV *Een opleiding volgen met een uitkering* Geraadpleegd op 3 februari 2026.
[27] UWV (2026) *Overzichtsdocument wettelijk en beleidskader inzet van arbeidsmarktgerichte scholing: januari 2026.*
[28] UWV (2025) *34 Oplossingen voor personeelstekorten*
[29] UWV (2024) *Oplossingen tekorten per beroepsgroep*
[30] UWV (2025) *Het zoekgedrag van werkzoekenden: inzichten voor gerichte werving en selectie*

Bijlage 1: Extra tabellen en figuren

Tabel 3. Redenen waarom vacatures moeilijk vervulbaar waren, per sector

Aandeel werkgevers met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures dat de reden noemt (meerdere redenen mogelijk)

	Industrie	Bouw	Groothandel	Vervoer en opslag	Informatie en communicatie	Verhuur en overige zakelijke diensten	Specialistische zakelijke diensten	Openbaar bestuur	Onderwijs	Gezondheidszorg	Totaal*
Te weinig reacties op vacature	87%	94%	76%	86%	74%	85%	95%	86%	81%	95%	87%
Benodigde vaardigheden onvoldoende aanwezig bij sollicitanten	67%	68%	64%	63%	87%	55%	61%	80%	61%	55%	64%
Specialistisch werk	65%	59%	63%	57%	77%	57%	85%	95%	51%	61%	62%
Vakkennis van sollicitanten is onvoldoende	64%	68%	62%	61%	72%	49%	61%	80%	52%	45%	59%
Concurrentie andere werkgevers	46%	65%	42%	63%	65%	55%	82%	64%	54%	62%	59%
Benodigde werkervaring ontbreekt bij sollicitanten	61%	61%	52%	51%	68%	50%	57%	83%	49%	42%	55%
Geen juiste instelling (motivatie) bij sollicitanten	62%	60%	58%	59%	39%	56%	38%	20%	34%	29%	53%
Wensen of eisen van sollicitanten waar we niet aan tegemoet kunnen komen	46%	33%	47%	46%	50%	42%	43%	36%	39%	44%	45%
Opleiding van sollicitanten niet passend	40%	34%	37%	43%	50%	31%	42%	58%	45%	52%	42%
Andere redenen	15%	12%	12%	11%	13%	13%	32%	10%	16%	16%	15%

* Het totaal van de sectoren is inclusief Horeca, Detail- en autohandel, Financiële instellingen, Sociaal werk, jeugdzorg en kinderopvang en Overige dienstverlening, cultuur, sport en recreatie. Deze sectoren zijn niet in de tabel weergegeven omdat het aantal werkgevers met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures kleiner dan 100 respondenten was.

Tabel 4. Wensen of eisen van sollicitant waar de werkgever niet aan tegemoet kon komen, per sector

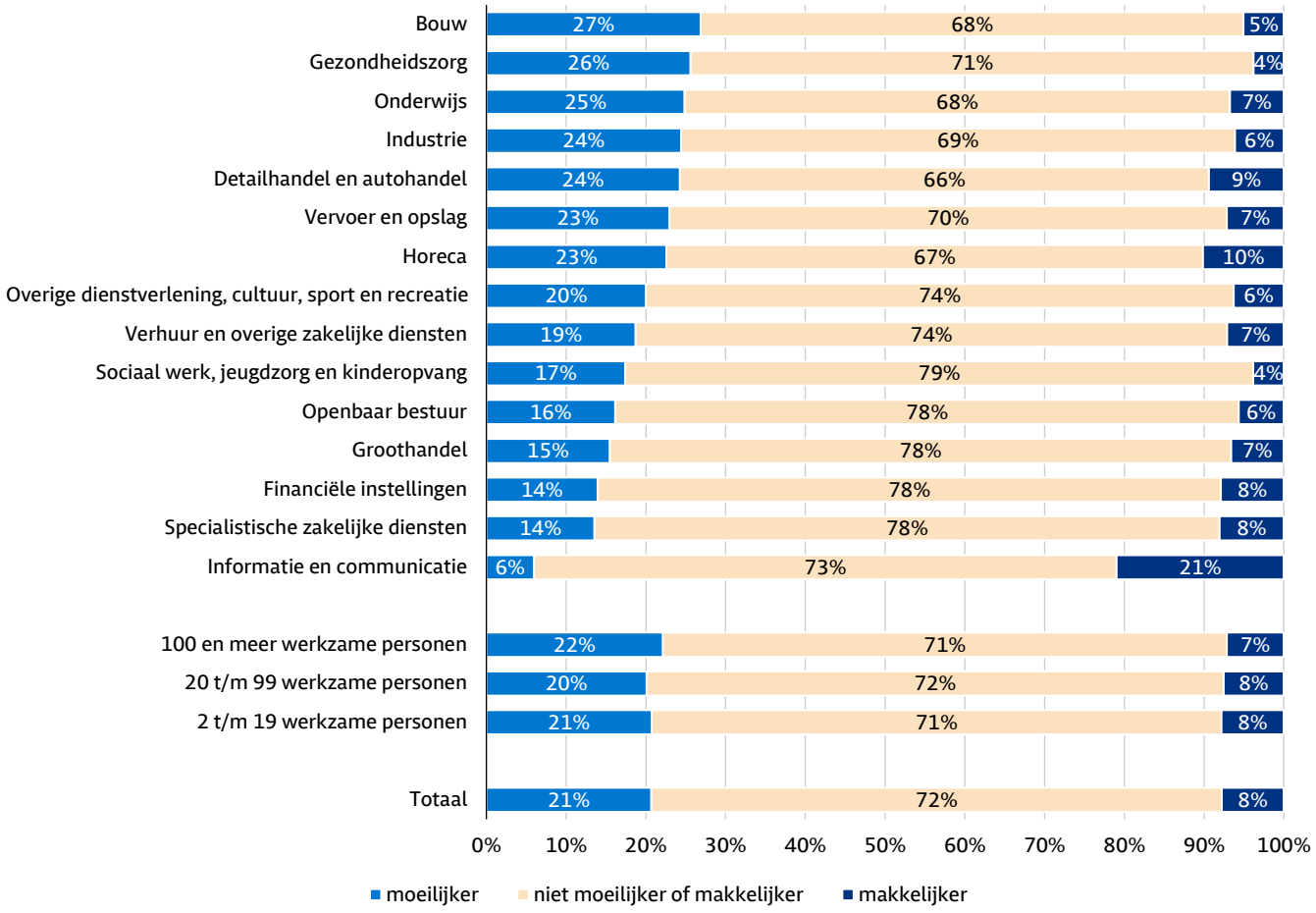
Aandeel werkgevers met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures dat de betreffende wens of eis van sollicitant noemt (meerdere antwoorden mogelijk)

	Industrie	Bouw	Groothandel	Vervoer en opslag	Informatie en communicatie	Verhuur en overige zakelijke diensten	Specialistische zakelijke diensten	Openbaar bestuur	Onderwijs	Gezondheidszorg	Totaal *
Salaris, bonussen of toeslagen	37%	25%	39%	38%	44%	26%	42%	30%	34%	35%	36%
Werktijden, roosters, beschikbaarheid of flexibiliteit hierin	17%	11%	26%	23%	12%	27%	8%	5%	18%	25%	23%
Minder werkuren wensen dan in de vacature	19%	18%	21%	21%	16%	14%	12%	10%	12%	18%	20%
Reistijd	16%	7%	13%	15%	20%	16%	10%	9%	8%	9%	13%
Thuis of hybride werken	14%	10%	17%	12%	16%	13%	16%	8%	5%	8%	12%
Secundaire arbeidsvoorwaarden	17%	7%	9%	15%	22%	11%	10%	15%	9%	11%	10%
Meer werkuren wensen dan in de vacature	5%	6%	0%	10%	6%	17%	3%	9%	8%	11%	9%
Langer lopend of vast contract	7%	4%	5%	11%	5%	5%	8%	7%	8%	6%	6%
Andere wensen	1%	-	-	4%	3%	-	1%	3%	6%	3%	1%

* Het totaal van de sectoren is inclusief Horeca, Detail- en autohandel, Financiële instellingen, Sociaal werk, jeugdzorg en kinderopvang en Overige dienstverlening, cultuur, sport en recreatie. Deze sectoren zijn niet in de tabel weergegeven omdat het aantal werkgevers met moeilijk vervulbare vacatures kleiner dan 100 respondenten was.

Figuur 7. Verwachting dat het vervullen van vacatures in volgend jaar moeilijker of makkelijker wordt

Aandeel werkgevers naar sector en omvangsklasse



Bijlage 2: Onderzoeksmethode

In opdracht van UWV heeft onderzoeksbureau Desan in de periode 15 september tot en met 12 december 2025 ruim 18.600 vestigingen van organisaties met minimaal twee werknemers benaderd met het verzoek mee te werken aan een telefonische enquête over werving van personeel. De netto respons bestond uit 3.551 bedrijfsvestigingen. Contactpersonen die niet in staat of bereid waren de vragen telefonisch te beantwoorden, kregen de optie aangeboden om de vragenlijst online in te vullen. Een klein deel van de respondenten (11%) heeft online deelgenomen aan het onderzoek.

Voor het onderzoek werd gebruik gemaakt van een gestratificeerde steekproef van bedrijfsvestigingen, ingedeeld naar zestien sectorclusters (zie tabel 1) en drie grootteklassen (2-19 werknemers, 20-99 werknemers en 100 of meer werknemers). Vestingen uit SBI-sectie A (landbouw, bosbouw en visserij) en SBI-afdeling 78 (arbeidsbemiddeling, uitzendbureaus en personeelsbeheer) zijn buiten beschouwing gelaten. Om ook voor afzonderlijke sectoren en grootteklassen onderzoeksresultaten weer te kunnen geven is gekozen voor een disproportionele steekproef met een minimumaantal waarnemingen per sectorcluster en grootteklasse. Doordat de resultaten zijn gewogen naar sector en grootteklasse kunnen representatieve uitspraken gedaan worden over de populatie van bedrijfsvestigingen in Nederland.

De vragenlijst voor het onderzoek is opgesteld door UWV. Thema's die aan de orde kwamen in de vragenlijst zijn 1) moeilijk vervulbare vacatures; 2) krapte op de arbeidsmarkt en oplossingen; 3) kunstmatige intelligentie en 4) uitstroom vanwege pensionering.

UWV verrichtte tevens de analyses van de enquêtedata. De onderzoeksuitkomsten worden door UWV verwerkt in verschillende kennisartikelen. Half februari 2026 zijn de eerste twee artikelen verschenen met de onderzoeksresultaten van thema 1 en 2. De onderzoeksuitkomsten van thema 3 en 4 worden in maart 2026 naar buiten gebracht.

Tabel 5. Gehanteerde namen van sectoren

Sector (SBI 2008)	Naam in publicatie
BCDE Delfstofwinning, Industrie, Energievoorziening, Waterbedrijven en afvalbeheer	Industrie
F Bouwnijverheid	Bouw
G 46 Groothandel	Groothandel
G 45 47 Autohandel en -reparatie en detailhandel	Detailhandel en autohandel
H Vervoer en opslag	Vervoer en opslag
I Horeca	Horeca
J Informatie en communicatie	Informatie en communicatie
K Financiële instellingen	Financiële instellingen
L N Onroerend goed en Verhuur van roerend goed en overige zakelijke dienstverlening (excl. 78 arbeidsbemiddeling etc.)	Verhuur en overige zakelijke diensten
M Advisering, onderzoek en overige specialistische zakelijke dienstverlening	Specialistische zakelijke diensten
O Openbaar bestuur, overheidsdiensten en verplichte sociale verzekeringen	Openbaar bestuur
P Onderwijs	Onderwijs
Q Gezondheidszorg (SBI afdeling 86, SBI-groepen 871, 872, 873, SBI-subklassen 88101, 88103)	Gezondheidszorg
Q Sociaal werk, jeugdzorg en kinderopvang (SBI-groepen 879, 889, SBI-subklasse 88102)	Sociaal werk, jeugdzorg, kinderopvang (SJK)
R Cultuur, sport en recreatie S Overige dienstverlening	Overige dienstverlening, cultuur, sport, recreatie

Colofon

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Postadres

Postbus 58285
1043 DL Amsterdam

Inlichtingen

Menno.wester@uwv.nl

Voor persvragen kunt u terecht bij onze woordvoerders via 020 687 5185.

Auteurs

Menno Wester

Volg ons

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Is COP still worth following? We think so. What matters for businesses is whether this year's COP31 can improve the business case for action. Here are four areas to watch

Coco Zhang and Gerben Hieminga

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energy demand... they have all made it harder for governments to turn climate commitments into action.

That raises an important question for businesses: Is the Conference of the Parties (COP) still worth following?

Our answer is yes.

Businesses do not just invest in climate targets; they invest in viable projects and operations. But many of them still face economic and practical barriers. Grid constraints and high electricity costs can slow electrification. Greener industrial products can struggle to

attract buyers willing to pay a premium. And climate adaptation plans do not always translate into investable projects.

Businesses cannot solve these challenges alone. In a 2025 UN survey of more than 2,000 CEOs across 128 countries, 92% said strong global governance and coordinated policy are “critical” or “important” to implementing their sustainability agendas.

That is why COP is still relevant. It can help align policy priorities, improving investment conditions, and connecting businesses with the right resources. At COP31, four areas will be particularly important for businesses to watch.

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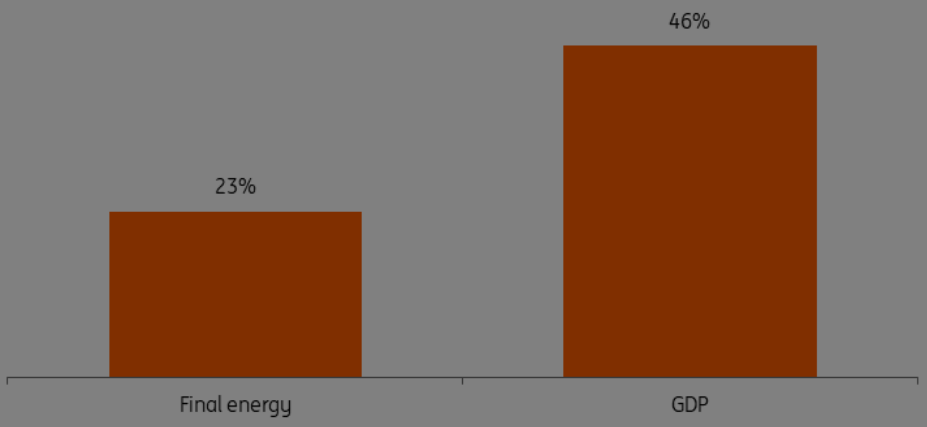
Global share of electricity in final energy and GDP, 2025, in %



Source: ING Research, International Energy Agency

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into direct technical assistance and ready-to-deploy models

- Set country- or sector-level targets and pathways to encourage industry alignment and commitment
- Improve access to finance by expanding dedicated financing for developing countries, while lowering upfront costs in Europe
- Improve the economics. Coordinate energy pricing reforms to make electrification more competitive with fossil fuel combustion alternatives, including by reducing taxes and grid fees that raise electricity prices
- Strengthen infrastructure by encouraging governments to reduce permitting barriers (e.g. Europe and the US), advance

regulatory support for power demand flexibility, and expand cross-border grids where needed (e.g. Southeast Asia)

If COP31 delivers meaningful action in these areas, the implications for businesses could be significant. Stronger policy could accelerate near-term grid connections and enhance long-term investment confidence. Meanwhile, companies may need to work more closely with utilities and regulators to secure the power they need.

Green industrialisation remains critical

But electrification is only part of the story. Industry is another major source of process emissions, with sectors such as steel

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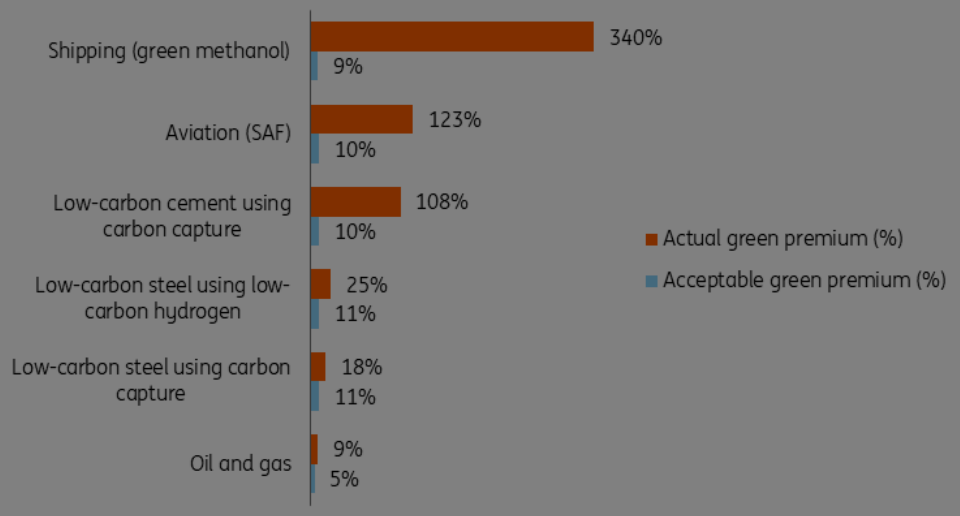
cleaner industrial products remains limited. And the necessary infrastructure for many is still underdeveloped.

Hard-to-abate sectors' green premium is way higher than what companies are willing to pay

Difference in cost, low-carbon versus conventional products, in %



Source: World Economic Forum, ING Research

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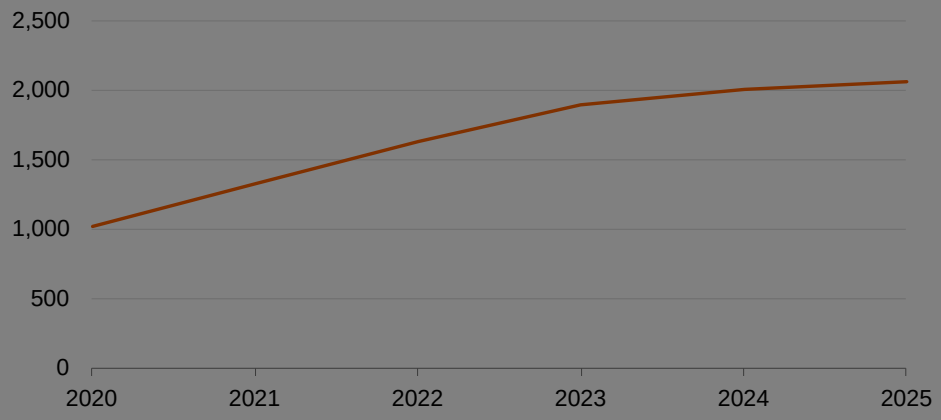
Global climate finance continues to grow

Finance levels in $bn



Source: Climate Policy Initiative, ING Research

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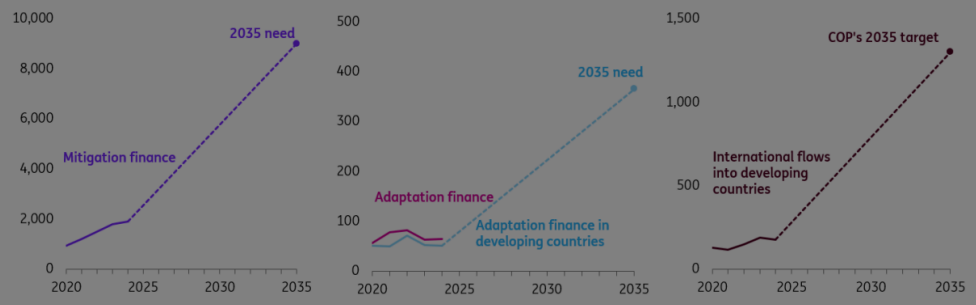
Finance levels in $bn



Source: ING Research, Climate Policy Initiative, UN, UNEP, Natural Resources Defense Council

More climate products and solutions are emerging in the latter two s… …e it … …e a… h… …ll l… f… s… i… …s.

A… i…

B… b… p… h… …y affecting supply chains across sectors. In aggregate, physical climate risks could cost companies in the S&P Global 1200 index $1.2tn annually by 2050.

One barrier to corporate investment in climate adaptation is that it is still seen primarily as a way to avoid losses. But adaptation can also create business value. Investments in resilient assets, cooling systems, supplier diversification and climate-resilient materials can improve reliability, competitiveness and long-term growth. Research from the World Resources Institute suggests that every $1 invested in adaptation can generate up to $10 in benefits. That return could be even higher for highly climate-exposed sectors. For

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example, the World Economic Forum estimates returns of $19–$43 per dollar invested in the food and beverage sector.

COP can help turn adaptation priorities into investable projects. Since the Paris Agreement, countries have developed National Adaptation Plans (NAPs), but many remain high-level and lack specific, actionable projects. Recent COP efforts have sought to change this by encouraging governments to translate their NAPs into portfolios of investable adaptation projects.

But identifying projects does not guarantee financing. This is where COP31 could make a difference. Its proposed Climate

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coordination and strong policy support. COP can bring governments and businesses together to provide such a framework, even amid geopolitical tensions and concerns over slowing progress. COP31 may not deliver a landmark global agreement, but practical advances in these four priorities could still have immediate relevance for businesses.

Sustainability | Corporates

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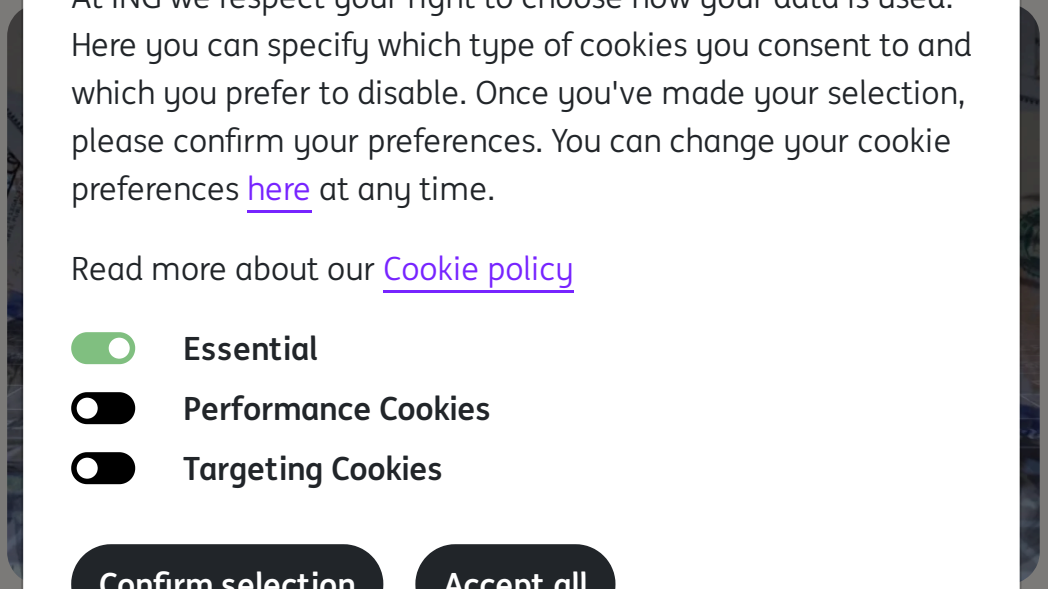
Tuesday will be nothing more than the day ahead of a much bigger day – Wednesday, by which time we'll have guidance on the midterm implications, and we'll have the US refunding announcement. In Europe, political jitters in Belgium highlight that France is not the only one struggling to consolidate its finances



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The midterms and refunding loom large on Wednesday

Two things for Treasuries to get their teeth into in the coming days. First, the signals from the midterm elections. Expect this to be an issue for trading on Wednesday, as projections emerge through Tuesday night. The basic market discount is for the Democrats to take the House, and maybe the Senate. The only big surprise would be if the Republicans held on to both, which would be a huge surprise, as it would, in fact, suggest an endorsement from the US

electorate for the war, tariffs and the current immigration policy, among other contentious issues that have emboldened the left and caused right-leaning independents to swing left. In all probability, this would be bond negative, on the theory that it's more of the same until disproven. The more probable blue sweep should have little market impact, as it should be broadly discounted.

The second big thing for Wednesday is the refunding announcement. At the previous one, there was a clear intimation of no change to the rhythm of issuance. And the questions posed to primary dealers a few weeks back did not suggest anything big or

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lowered the outlook on France's A+ rating to negative, citing weaker growth, higher borrowing costs and a wider deficit since the August review. Nonetheless, the 10y OAT/Bund spread still tightened by around 4bp against the backdrop of a broader tightening in government bond spreads at the start of the week, which seems to have been driven by some easing of geopolitical tensions, with oil prices coming off their highs. To be fair, France has been trading at levels more akin to a BBB name for some time already, suggesting spreads are already wider than pure fundamentals would imply.

There was one important exception to the tightening trend. In contrast to the broader trend, 10y Belgian government bond spreads widened by up to 4bp versus Bunds. The backdrop was that the prime minister tendered his resignation after his coalition failed to agree on a budget. The King did not immediately accept the resignation and called on coalition parties to find a compromise. The King will receive the prime minister next on 6 November. The headlines underscore that it is not only France that faces the challenge of consolidating its finances. In the summer, the Belgian central bank forecast a deficit of 5.3% for this year and 5.5% in 2027.

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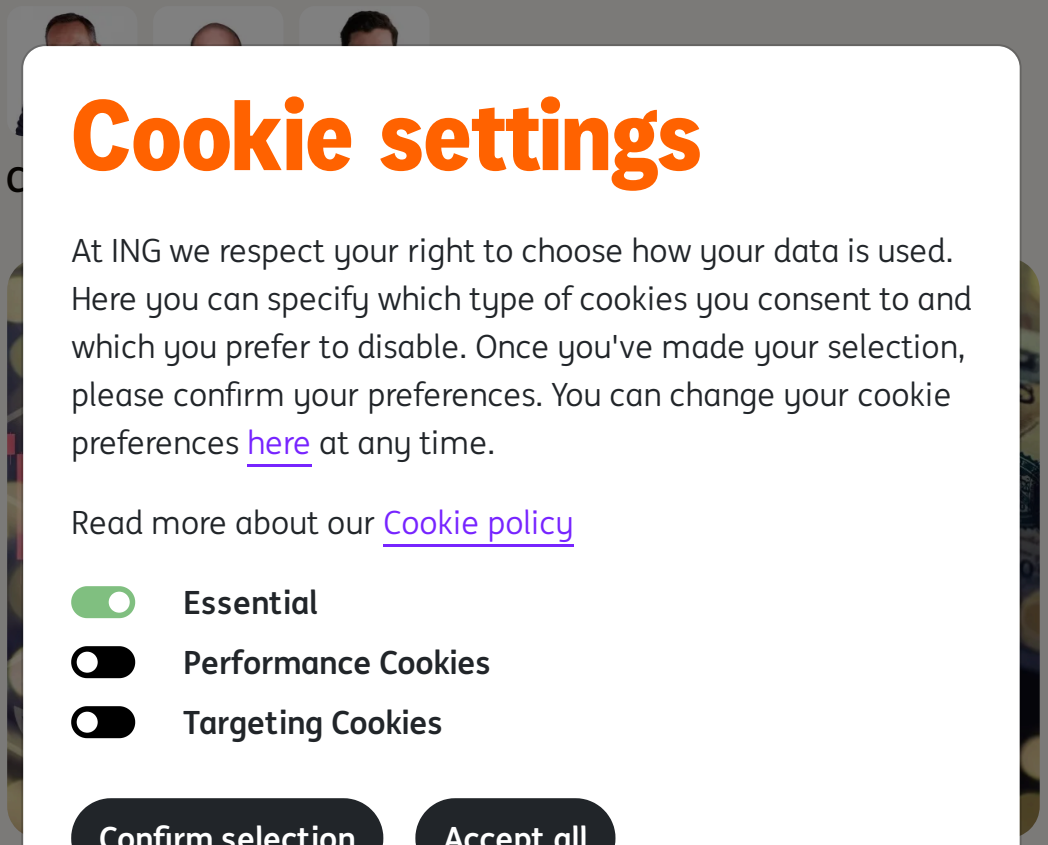
At the start of a very busy week for FX markets, the dollar is largely holding onto recent gains. In focus are the US midterms, where betting markets attach a 70% probability to a clean sweep for the Democrats. Away from politics, we'll receive updates on the US jobs market this week and are expecting rate hikes in the UK, Australia and Sweden



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USD: Contemplating the midterms

The dollar is fractionally lower at the start of the week. It may be taking its cue from oil prices, which are off 2-3% on reports that US President Donald Trump wants to let diplomacy run its course with Iran. That reverses Friday's sentiment, where some had positioned for a fresh attack this weekend. Please see our latest thoughts on the oil market here.

In focus this week are the US midterm elections. Betting websites give the Democrats a 70-72% chance of taking both the House and the Senate. One could make the case that the dollar should come lower on such an outcome, since it would likely lead to gridlock on the debt ceiling, a prolonged government shutdown next year and could encourage President Trump to pursue an even more activist foreign policy agenda. Many of those views are speculative, however. What is not speculative is the US economy posting a strong 3.4% quarter-on-quarter annualised growth rate in the third quarter, inflation remaining above target for a sixth year in a row, and the Federal Reserve readying to tighten again.

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Chris Turner

EUR: Fitch puts the boot in

Unwelcome news for French politicians late Friday came in the form of an unscheduled ratings review from Fitch. It shifted its outlook on French sovereign debt from stable to negative and promised another ratings review by the end of February. It currently rates France as A+. Reasons for the outlook shift are familiar by now, but they centre on the government's failure to improve public finances at a time of weak growth. Let's see whether this unscheduled move

puts much pressure on the OAT-Bund spread today. We would think that the news limits the potential for EUR/USD to rebound on softer energy prices.

We suspect there will be more EUR/USD sellers in the 1.1200/1250 area should it make it that far. The news should also keep EUR/CHF pressured towards Friday's lows at 0.9180/85.

Chris Turner

GBP: 25bp BoE rate hike fully priced for Thursday

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CEE: Central bank divergence meets renewed FX pressure

With the start of a new month, the CEE narrative is becoming more attractive once again. Today, PMI data for the region will be released. Since the onset of the US-Iran conflict, these figures have either remained stagnant or trended upward, indicating that the economies are currently showing strong resilience to the energy shock.

Tomorrow, we will see Turkey's inflation figures for October. Our estimates suggest a monthly acceleration from 1.8% to 2.4%, while the year-on-year figure is expected to tick lower to 29.6%.

On Wednesday, Hungary's industrial production data and the Czech Republic's October inflation figures will be published. We anticipate an acceleration in headline inflation from 2.5% to 2.6%, and a further rise in core inflation from 3.1% to 3.3%. The National Bank of Poland is also expected to keep rates unchanged at 3.75% and present a new forecast. We do not anticipate the first rate hike until the first quarter of 2027.

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meetings. We could see the pair move slightly above 24.350 again.

Frantisek Taborsky

FX

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The oil market is likely to remain nervous this week ahead of the US midterm elections. The market has been increasingly pricing in the risk of escalation in the Persian Gulf following the elections, but there is still a glimmer of hope for diplomacy

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Oil prices finished strong last week, with ICE Brent settling almost 2.4% higher on Friday to close above $113/bbl. It was also the Dec-26 contract expiry; it settled at $117.64/bbl on its last trading day. Vessels have faced a growing number of attacks in recent weeks. Yet this coincides with signs that more traffic is flowing through the Strait of Hormuz. Fears remain high over the potential for fresh US and Israeli strikes on Iran following the US midterms. Reports say that President Trump wants to give diplomacy a chance are weighing on prices in early morning trading today. Iranian negotiators have been in Doha over the weekend, holding talks with

Qatari mediators. It remains to be seen whether this will lead to anything.

The price action in oil in recent weeks reflects a market increasingly bracing for the potential for more hostilities between the US and Iran. If the midterms pass with neither strikes nor a deal, the key question is whether the market continues to price in a substantial geopolitical risk premium or whether that premium gradually begins to unwind. Given that many of the key developments in this conflict have unfolded over weekends, the market may have to hold its breath until the end of the week.

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net long in ICE Brent by 3,576 lots over the last reporting week to 245,457 lots as of last Tuesday. Fresh longs drove the move. Meanwhile, the net speculative long is still some distance away from the year-to-date high of around 430k lots seen in March. This suggests that with the right catalyst, speculators could add to this position. A strong catalyst would be needed, though, given that from a risk-reward perspective it may not make sense to take too much risk on the long side at current price levels.

European gas prices saw significant strength at the end of last week, with TTF settling more than 6% higher on Friday, near

EUR104/MWh. Prices eased slightly in early morning trading today. Weather forecasts for NW Europe show colder-than-usual weather this week, leading to potentially large storage draws. EU gas storage peaked at just under 75% last Tuesday and has been edging lower since, suggesting the heating season is now underway. With a tight balance through the winter, the market is likely to remain extremely volatile, and weather will prove to be even more important than usual.

Metals - Gold hits one-year low

Gold fell to its lowest level in a year at the end of last week as oil p
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narrowed by almost $48/t on Friday to $174.85/t, but remains elevated, while the Yangshan premium rose above $200/t last week. This suggests refined copper availability remains constrained despite the pullback in futures prices. That tightness should provide a floor under prices, although at elevated levels we could see some resistance from price-sensitive demand.

Agriculture — Corn slides on harvest pressure

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CBOT corn prices extended losses for a second consecutive month, falling nearly 11% last month, the largest monthly decline since June 2023. The sell-off was driven by increased harvest supplies, weaker export demand, and easing concerns over Black Sea disruptions. US farmers had harvested 60% of their corn crop as of 25 October, up from 44% a week earlier, boosting near-term supply. Weekly US corn export sales declined 15% week-on-week to 1,303.9kt as of 22 October.

Market sentiment is under pressure amid expectations of lower geopolitical risk following renewed discussions involving Russia, Ukraine, and the US. This could mean more stable grain shipments fr
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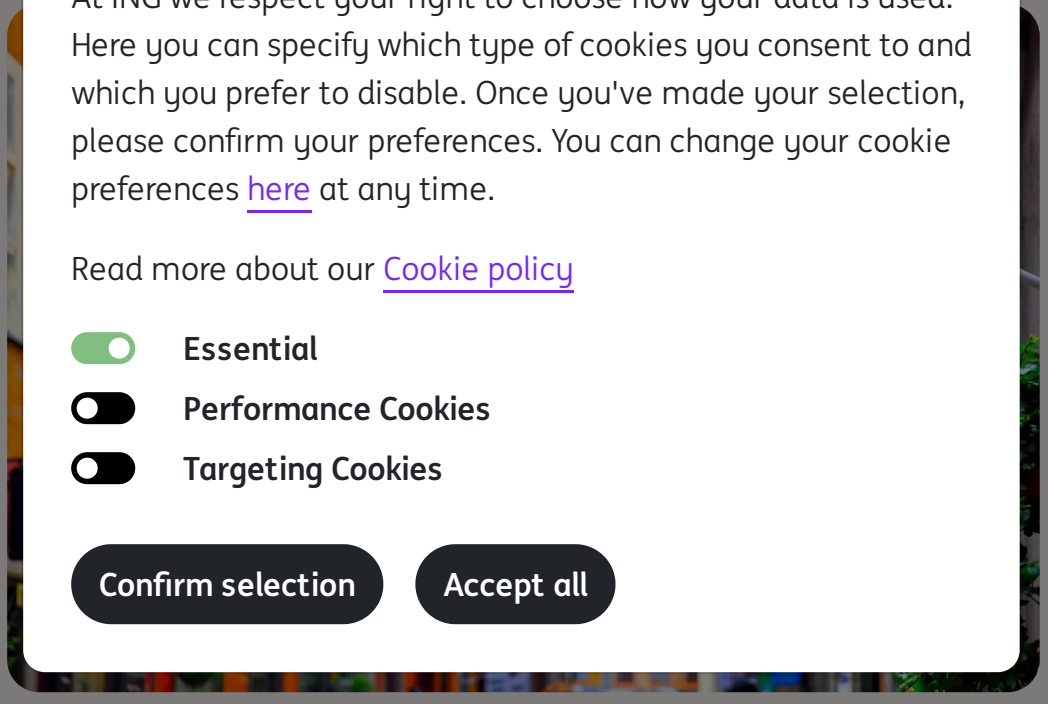
We expect a 25bp hike on 4 November by the Riksbank, alongside a reiteration of the tightening bias. Inflation was softer than expected in September, but upside risks remain for prices, and a resilient economy allows policymakers to tighten pre-emptively. We have revised our EUR/SEK year-end target to 11.00 after the recent rally



We expect two rate hikes in Sweden in the next few months

The Riksbank announces policy on 4 November, and we are sticking to our call for a 25bp rate hike to 2.0%. Market bets on a rate increase next week have dwindled in the past week or so, moving from 22-24bp to 15-18bp. While we don't see a single clear trigger for this partial dovish rethink, a soft inflation print in September and SEK appreciation may have both played a role.

However, both in-meeting and off-meeting commentary by Riksbank officials have been endorsing a move at this November

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meeting, and the rise in energy prices offsets the dovish inflation and currency market inputs, in our view.

Don't expect an explicit commitment to further increases, but the tightening bias should remain in place. Our call remains that the Riksbank will skip December and hike again to 2.25% on 3 February. We don't currently expect any further rate increases beyond that, but the risks are clearly on the hawkish side given the persistence of energy price inflation.

Muted inflation in September, but goods prices are picking up

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in core measures, with CPIF excluding energy set to pass 2.0% by the summer.

Growth proved resilient again in 3Q, with GDP rising 0.4% quarter-on-quarter and 2.8% YoY.

Higher energy prices to tilt the balance towards November

These inflation projections are only facing upside risks the longer energy prices remain elevated. Alongside them, the Riksbank

signalled a split probability rates would be raised at either the November or December meeting.

While the September inflation print and stronger krona (which we address below as a topic) may argue for a pause, the rise in energy prices is a bigger deciding factor in our view, and should tilt the balance towards a rate hike already next week. In September, the Brent crude price projection for end-2026 was $92/bbl, against the current price of $118. European gas prices have also increased c.35% since the September meeting. New projections are only published in December, but we think the Riksbank will have to acknowledge that higher energy prices increase the risk of more p

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Source: ING, Riksbank, Refinitiv

Riksbank shouldn't underestimate SEK fragility if it holds

There's no denying that the hawkish shift in September was partly due to the Swedish krona's weakness. Since that last policy meeting, the krona has appreciated c.1.4% on a trade-weighted basis, driven by a drop in EUR/SEK. That, in turn, has been a consequence of a tightening in two-year swap rate differentials of around 20bp, mirroring a stable outlook for Riksbank tightening while ECB expectations were revised lower on the back of French-related risk.

EUR/SEK was also trading 1-2% above our short-term fair value estimates at the end of September. The subsequent rise in euro idiosyncratic risk has pushed the pair into a modest 0.5-1%

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the past couple of months. The build-up of substantial EUR-specific risk makes a lower target an obvious adjustment. Markets are also not fully pricing a Riksbank hike next week, with 17bp priced at the time of writing, nor a February follow-up move, with 40bp priced, which remains our baseline.

Still, EUR/SEK looks a bit too weak relative to fundamentals. That points to a lingering risk premium and leaves room for upside if some France-related risk abates into year-end (our baseline). At the same time, the external backdrop remains challenging for SEK, with oil prices still very elevated.

We are revising our year-end EUR/SEK target to 11.00, close to current spot. Over the next week, however, we could see further downside exploration, with a potential break below 10.90, as a Riksbank hike may combine with some US-related risk around the midterms to support SEK, both through the rates channel and potential capital repatriation flows.

In the longer run, we still expect a gradual decline to 10.70 over the course of next year.

SEK Riksbank FX

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AT1 reform may remain on the back burner in 2027, leaving the instruments' role in bank capital largely unchanged. Solid fundamentals remain supportive, while supply should be manageable – but tight(ish) spreads and low reset levels could weigh on the market

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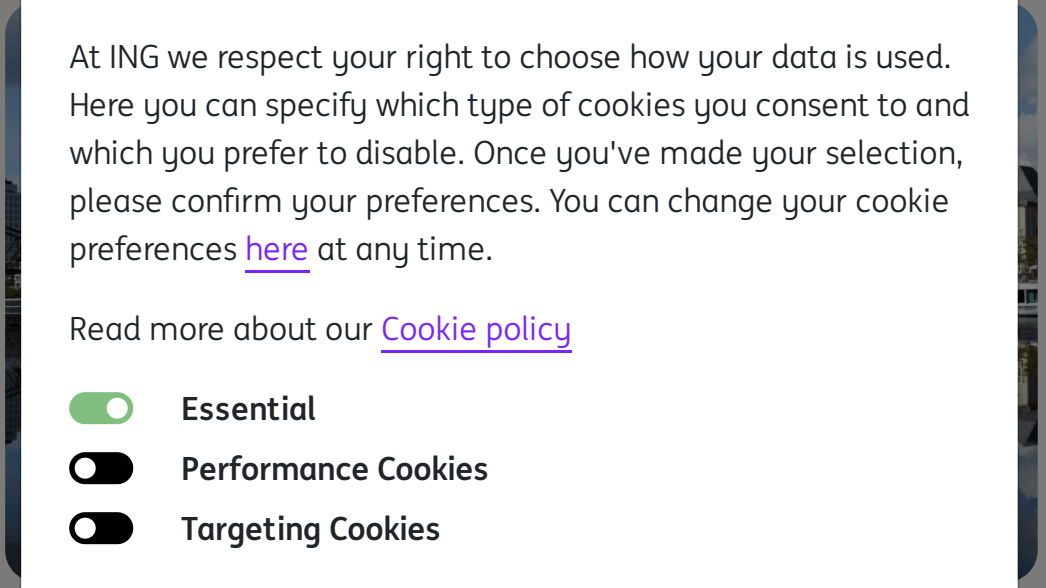

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AT1 reform remains on the back burner

The European Commission published its report on competitiveness in the banking sector in July but did not include much in the way of proposals for AT1 bank capital instruments. The report mainly focused on reducing complexity, reporting requirements and improving competitiveness for Europe's banking sector.

For AT1, this probably means that the instruments are unlikely to be phased out anytime soon. What is somewhat relevant for AT1s is the Commission's intention to reduce complexity for bank capital structures. This includes making the Pillar 2 requirement and

guidance more transparent, while the Commission also proposes to consolidate parts of the buffers into two buffers: one that can be released in periods of stress, and another that would be maintained in all scenarios.

This, in theory, could reduce the risk of coupon skips, as being able to release buffers during periods of stress would not automatically lead to a breach of the combined buffer requirements. The proposals also include a removal of the leverage ratio Pillar 2 capital requirement, which would affect the largest European systemically important banks subject to this requirement. This is only a small number of banks but could (in theory) lead to a marginal decline in A

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line with expectations in 2026. EUR AT1 issuance has just passed €15bn at the time of writing, slightly above our expectation of €15bn. Similarly, EUR Tier 2 has reached €27bn, nearing our expectation of €30bn for 2026.

In 2027, we expect a modest increase in supply, largely dominated by the refinancing of upcoming redemptions/calls. We expect **€20bn in AT1 supply**, compared to €14bn of calls. While this represents a step-up, incremental net supply is only around €3bn higher than in 2026. Tier 2 redemptions will also rise by around

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€3bn next year, supporting our increased supply expectation of **€35bn in Tier 2.**

While gross supply will be higher, net supply should remain easily absorbable. More supply should create opportunities in primary markets, although lower reset levels have left some recently issued bonds more exposed during weaker markets.

AT1 redemptions pick up next year

(€bn)

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highest level since 2002. The story in French markets is growing more sinister by the day. But contagion risk across the eurozone is (so far) relatively contained. Italy and Belgium stand out as other higher-risk countries, given high debt levels and deficits, but it remains a French story for now. Nonetheless, the domestic sovereign exposure and the sovereign-bank nexus have come back into play.

So far, the market is not questioning the broader future of the eurozone. Still, France is of a much larger magnitude than countries

such as Greece or even Italy, which had to be supported during the eurozone crisis.

What can be said is that French banks, as well as the broader European banking sector, are in much better shape than they were during the eurozone crisis. French banks' capital ratios have increased significantly and now stand at around 13-15% on average, compared to c.9-10% during the eurozone crisis. Liquidity levels are healthy, while earnings and exposures, particularly for the larger banks, are well diversified. For instance, BNP Paribas generated around 25% of its revenues in 2025 in France, while French deposits account for 29% of the total. For Société Générale, F

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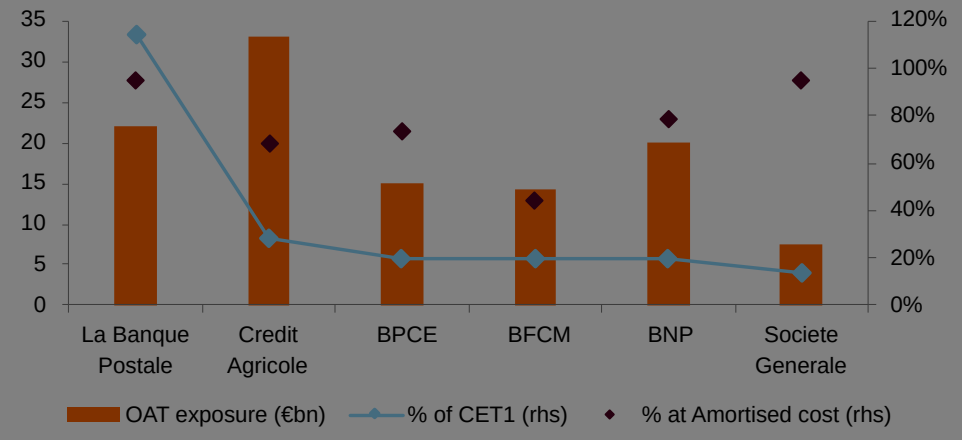
French banks OAT exposure appears manageable



Source: Company reports, EBA, ING

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However, we do not think this is the same sovereign-bank loop as in 2009-2012. European Central Bank funding facilities, the Bank Recovery and Resolution Directive (BRRD) and stronger liquidity coverage ratio (LCR) and net stable funding ratio (NSFR) requirements have reduced banks' dependence on sovereign guarantees. The link remains: ratings, domestic bond holdings and a shared operating environment still transmit sovereign stress into bank funding costs and market access.

The flip side is that liquidity requirements and favourable EU sovereign risk weights have made banks important buyers of government debt. As ECB purchases ended and TLTROs were repaid, sovereign holdings have partly replaced central bank reserves for LCR purposes. Banks rely less on sovereign guarantees, but on the other hand, sovereigns arguably rely more on banks for funding.

This new relationship, alongside expectations that the ECB would contain broader spillovers, perhaps helps explain why bank spreads have not widened as much as OATs. The ECB's refinancing and bond purchase tools remain part of the toolkit, although they have p

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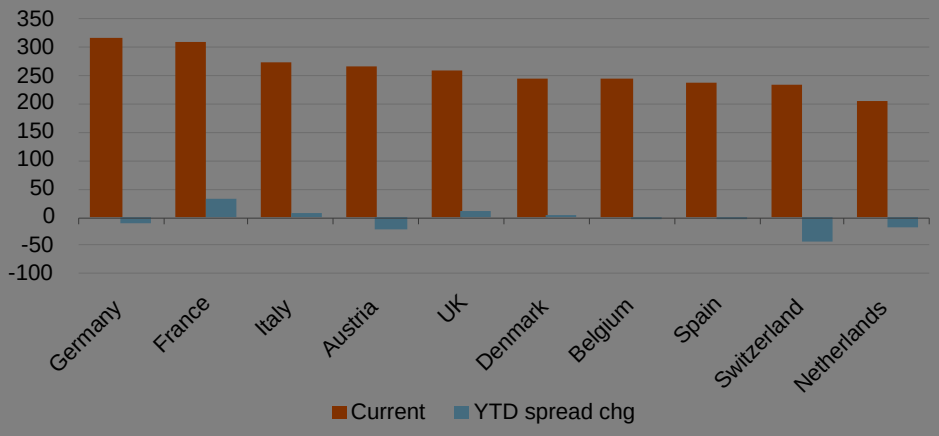
We would avoid treating all French banks similarly. Sensitivity to OATs and the French economy differ quite a bit across issuers. As such, the recent widening has been quite uniform, but the market could become more selective in French AT1s if nervousness continues into 2027. We think the most diversified names, including BNP and ACAFP in short-call bonds, with high reset levels, should hold up better.

French AT1 spreads trade at the widest levels in EUR



Source: IHS Markit, ING

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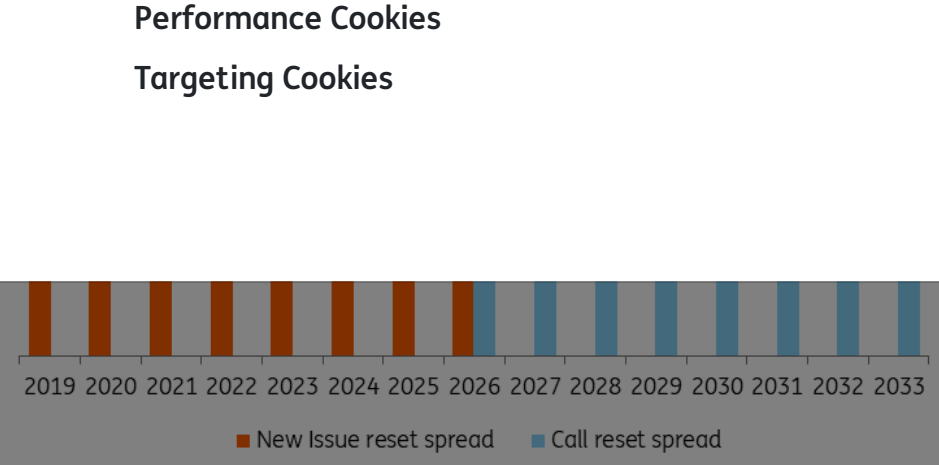
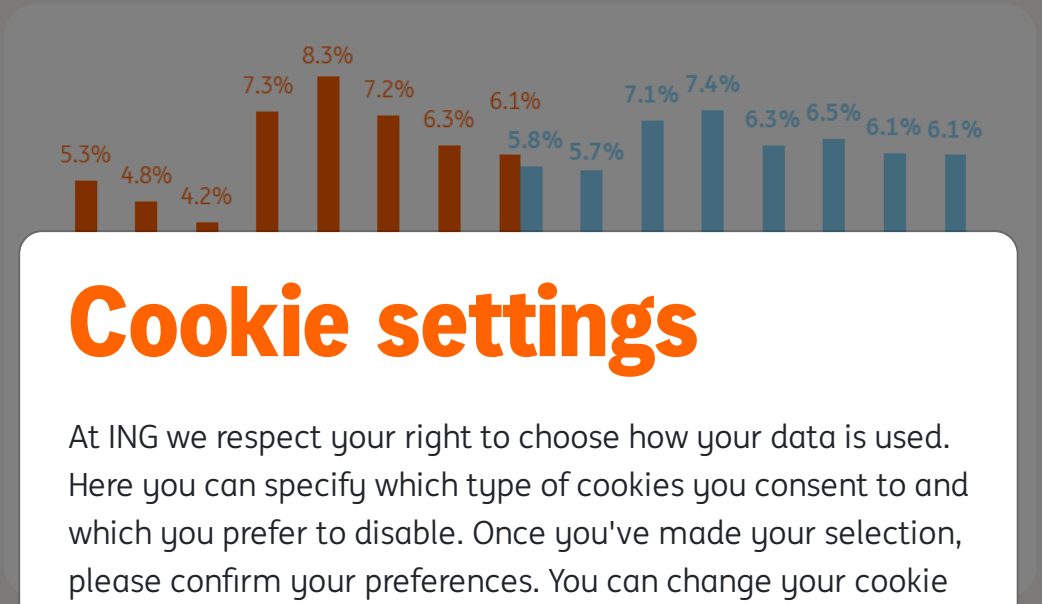


Source: IHS Markit, ING

This is especially the case as the reset levels remain low, while overall coupon levels are in line with recent historical averages. **The economics become less comfortable further out**. Reset spreads decline for bonds callable from 2030 onwards, leaving these bonds

more sensitive to higher rates and deterioration in market access. However, reset levels remain high on average through to 2029 callable bonds.

AT1 coupons have declined, but still remain elevated



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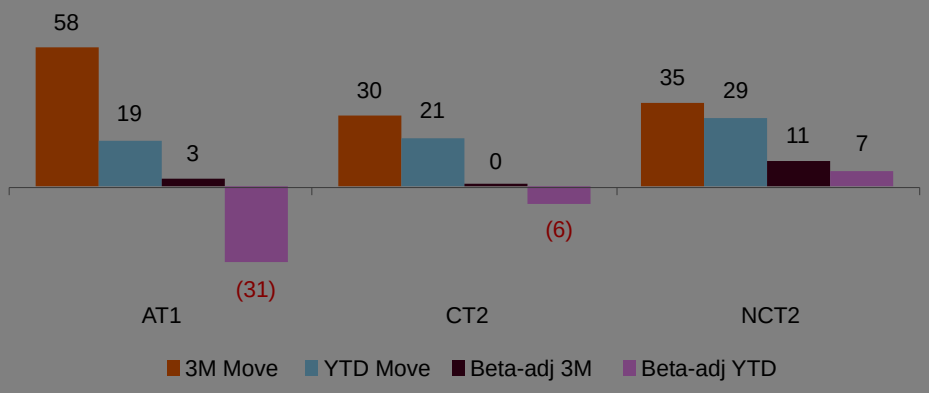
basis, suggesting the recent sell-off has reversed the trend a little bit.

AT1 has widened in recent months as volatility has come back to markets



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points.

Reset has mattered more than ratings

High reset spread AT1s have generally been more resilient in 2026, with the 700-800bp reset bucket outperforming by quite a bit over the last three months. While this relationship is not fully linear, and many high-reset bonds are issued by higher beta/lower rated issuers, numbers still suggest that reset levels have been an important driver of performance this year. Higher underlying rates reduce the cushion that lower reset AT1 bonds have had, as

extension risk concerns have made more of a comeback in recent months.

Higher reset levels also provide greater coupon protection if a bond is extended during a period of market stress. There are a few near-term low-reset bonds callable with reset levels below +380bp. However, extension risk is still low for these: longer-call AT1s from these issuers trade through the respective reset levels, and these banks have historically assessed calls holistically, rather than purely on an economics or bond-by-bond basis.

Higher-rated bonds have underperformed in 2026. IG-rated bonds h
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So where does that leave the AT1 market in 2027?

2027 is shaping up to be another interesting year for bank capital. Valuations look a bit compressed, but bank fundamentals remain solid, with banks likely to continue calling their instruments at the first call dates. In terms of supply, we expect the small increase to be absorbable but potentially lead to investors becoming a bit more price sensitive. Furthermore, the lack of imminent AT1 reform

should mean the asset class retains an important role in Europe's banking capital stacks for the foreseeable future.

There are risks becoming more visible, not least through sovereign and fiscal concerns, with France the obvious victim at the moment. A softening of fundamentals at the margin and lower reset levels further along the call curve could create more volatility. Spreads have recently seen some widening, yet there is probably greater scope for spreads to stay wider than for further tightening in 2027.

AT1 yields could remain a good driver of demand for

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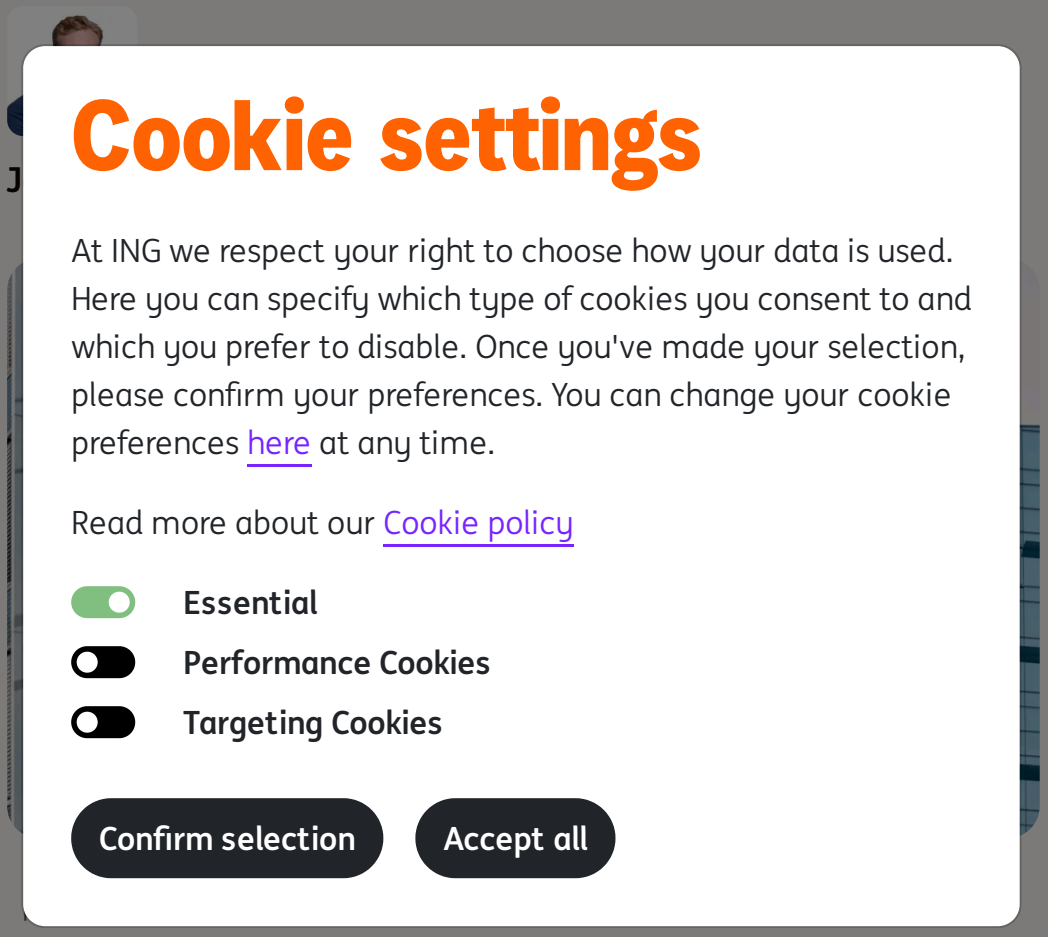
European bank M&A has seen a resurgence in recent years, and 2027 should stay busy. Domestic deals still dominate, while cross-border consolidation is harder but is also picking up. Regulation is becoming more supportive, but politics and execution still matter. Expect more deals, but a transformation of Europe's banking sector is still some way off



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European bank M&A is back

European bank M&A has seen a strong resurgence, with several large-scale deals making headlines. UniCredit's high-stakes takeover of Commerzbank, once deemed very unlikely but now moving closer to completion, could be Europe's most significant cross-border transaction in years. Italy remains one of Europe's bank M&A hotbeds, with multiple banks taking part in the ongoing consolidation wave. Other banks have also been active, and we expect M&A to remain elevated in 2027.

Year-to-date M&A deal value has already surpassed the 2025 total, reaching €53bn including the UniCredit-Commerzbank transaction and based on deals valued at €100m or more. Furthermore, deals pending or intended total €39bn, which includes the potential takeover of Banca Monte dei Paschi by Intesa Sanpaolo, currently valued at around €34bn. All in, this would bring deal value back to levels not seen since the early 2010s.

European bank M&A volumes have seen a resurgence

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Today, the backdrop has shifted – profitability and capital levels are stronger, making the obvious cost-efficiency story less compelling on its own. Instead, banks are using M&A to add scale, deposits and fee-generating diversification, while the need to close the gap with US rivals remains a key driver.

The industrial logic has also strengthened, as fixed costs are rising in areas such as technology, AI, compliance, as well as personnel. Rising investment requirements mean that remaining subscale is becoming more expensive, even for highly profitable banks.

Domestic dominates, but cross-border competes

UniCredit-Commerzbank remains the sector's most closely watched deal and could become the first major cross-border acquisition since the financial crisis. UniCredit has slowly been building its stake rather than a clean takeover and is now deemed to hold effective control, despite currently owning around 50% of the shares. Furthermore, it is also not entirely a leap into an unfamiliar market, as UniCredit already has a significant banking business in Germany through its subsidiary, HVB.

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broad-based cross-border consolidation wave. Many involve banks already familiar with the target market or assets that complement an existing local business.

Selected transaction details

Transaction	Type	Status	Deal value + Stake	Strategic rationale	Main implication
UniCredit / Commerzbank	Staged cross-border takeover	Pending control (ECB approval received)	c.49% owned; c.50% voting rights expected	Scale in Germany and HVB overlap	Landmark cross-border test; politics still shape execution
Intesa / Monte dei Paschi (MPS)	Domestic cash-and-shares bid	Announced / likely	€30.6bn initially; later improved to c€34bn	Scale, deposits and market leadership	Likely branch disposals and competition remedies
MPS / Mediobanca	Domestic takeover and merger	Completed; integration under way	€16bn	CIB, wealth and Generali stake	Transforms MPS business mix and reduces governance complexity
MPS / Banco BPM	Merger of equals	**Unlikely**	€25.3bn	Italy mid-tier consolidation	Italy mid-tier consolidation
MPS / Banca Generali	Merger of equals	**Unlikely**	Part of c.€34bn twin proposals	Adds wealth mgmt scale and fee income	Growth in MPS wealth and mid-tier banking
BPER / Popolare di Sondrio	Domestic merger	Completed Apr-26	€4.3bn initial offer	Northern Italy scale and deposits	Clear domestic synergy case
BPCE / Novo Banco	Full cross-border acquisition	Completed Apr-26	€6.7bn	Portugal as second domestic market	Large but operationally separate expansion
BPCE / Sabadell	Strategic minority stake	Completed; cooperation talks	7% stake for c.€1.2bn; cap 9.9%	Spanish exposure, board role and partnerships	Optionality without control; strengthens Sabadell defences
Santander / Webster	Cross-border takeover	Completed	$12.5bn	Geographic scale, creating a top-10 US bank	Bolt-on acquisition in commercial markets

Source: Company reports, ING

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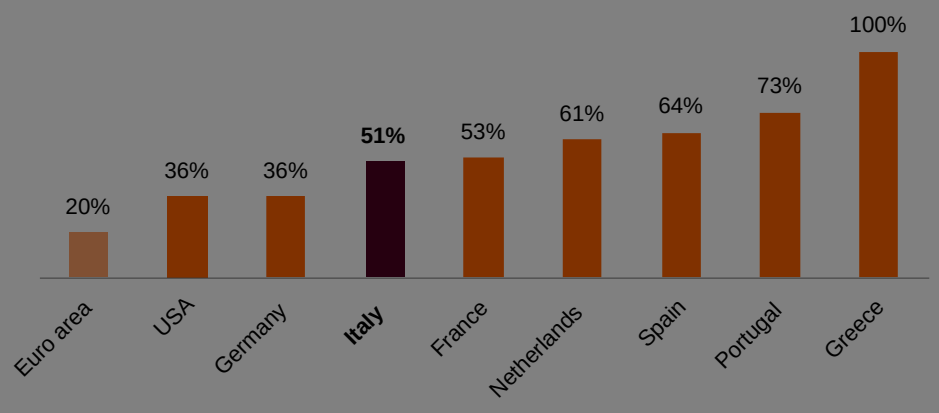
Why is Italy so active in particular? Well, Italy remains quite fragmented (see below) and still offers a large domestic synergy pool, even after the wave of M&A that has already taken place. Furthermore, the country has meaningful industrial scale and offers further revenue diversification opportunities for banks and insurers. Although the obvious combinations are becoming less evident in Italy, we expect this to continue to drive M&A activity in 2027.

Top 5 banks' lending market share by country (2025)



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Deutsche's return to life insurance after more than a decade.

Consolidation can support bank performance

But does consolidation actually deliver better outcomes? The evidence is not entirely clear-cut, but overall points in the right direction. While increasing scale is not always the best use of capital, in general, more consolidated markets tend to have more stable and, in some cases, higher profitability. The ECB is in favour of further consolidation where appropriate, as it sees the benefits of

diversification and efficiency. On the other hand, capital can be reduced following a merger. This could be a downside, as better capitalised banks tend to enjoy lower funding costs and thus have more room to lend to the real economy.

The outcome therefore depends on the trade-off between longer-term synergies and the upfront capital, execution and integration costs.

ECB data show an association between more concentrated banking markets and profitability. As the chart below shows, countries with a high level of concentration (defined by a higher Herfindahl-

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Herfindahl-Hirschman Index (Sector concentration)

Source: ECB, ING

Similarly, a higher level of market concentration in European countries is associated with a lower cost of risk. The correlation is modest, with some clear outliers, but the numbers show that greater concentration can lead to lower asset quality costs, although the relationship should perhaps not be interpreted as causal. Still, taken together, this suggests that consolidation can improve banking markets.

Cost of risk vs market concentration for European countries (2025)

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clearer than it was even a decade ago. But as the Draghi report noted, the incomplete Banking Union means Europe's banks remain less profitable than their US counterparts.

There is a shift underway, though. The EU Commission plans to table a broad **Banking Package** in the first quarter of 2027, with measures covering cross-border capital and liquidity management, deposit insurance, prudential rules and other items. For M&A, the most important proposals include those to give banking groups more flexibility to allocate capital and liquidity more efficiently within cross-border groups, while also applying more consistent

treatment to intra-group exposures. These remain proposals rather than agreed implementations, meaning their final scope and timetable remain uncertain.

The AFME estimates that regulatory ring-fencing rules mean that some €225bn of capital and €250bn of liquidity is trapped within subsidiaries, which banks cannot freely move between parent and subsidiaries. Freeing this up could also support more cross-border transactions.

Regulatory ring-fencing traps subsidiaries' capital and liquidity

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cross-border M&A. CMDI reform has been passed this year, which could make it easier to deal with failing banks, potentially making consolidation easier as well, although the direct impact on M&A is unclear.

The Danish compromise, which is now embedded into CRR3, allows banks to risk-weight certain insurance subsidiaries rather than deduct them from regulatory capital. This was clarified by the EBA in January 2026, and some banks such as UniCredit have received authorisation to use the Danish Compromise methodology for its insurance subsidiaries. This has improved the economics of

bancassurance and could support further bank-insurance transactions.

On the other hand, national regulatory and political intervention has also put the brakes on M&A in some cases, raising execution costs and uncertainty. BBVA's proposed acquisition of Sabadell in 2024 illustrates the problem. It took 539 days from the announcement in May 2024 to the offer failing in October 2025.

For us, the message seems clear that European regulators are seeking to improve bank competitiveness, and they see consolidation as an important part of this. Looking ahead, re

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so we could see more bolt-ons. In the UK, challenger banks and neobanks are gaining ground while deposit competition remains intense, potentially leading to more activity. The Benelux has potential catalysts following a series of government ownership reductions and increasing inorganic ambitions.

Cross-border activity could also remain elevated, but we think the real litmus test remains the UniCredit-Commerzbank deal, including what happens after completion in terms of execution and integration, a process that is likely to take a few years. The

regulatory environment should also become increasingly more supportive for cross-border M&A from 2027 onwards.

Overall, 2027 could be another interesting year.

M&A is here to stay

European bank M&A has picked up in recent years, and we expect more activity again in 2027, although we do not see a big bang. For investors, positioning is inherently speculative. For bondholders, the main way to gain is by owning the target entity's bonds. However, this is not always the case, and bigger doesn't always mean better, as credit ratings don't necessarily improve either following an

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The Solvency II amendments are unlikely to result in a material increase in demand for bank bonds. Securitisations benefit most directly through lower capital charges, while covered bonds could benefit modestly from the new liquidity-buffer rules

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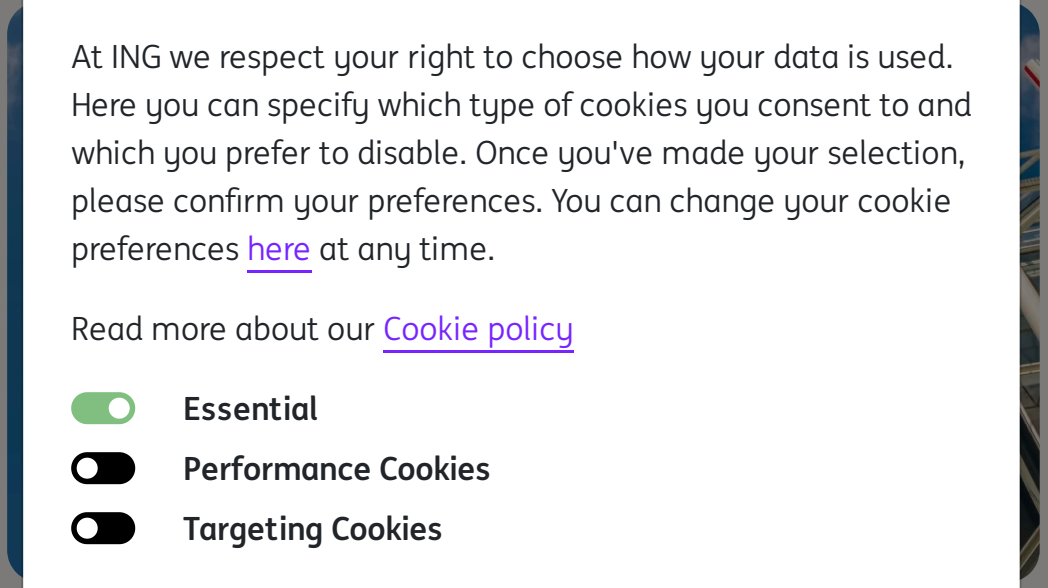

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will apply, making these revisions one of the important regulatory themes for 2027. One of the key objectives of the Solvency II reforms is to release capital and promote long-term investments by European insurance companies in support of the ambitions of Europe's Savings and Investments Union (SIU). Such capital release could also increase the capacity of insurance companies to invest more in corporate and bank bonds.

During the past decade, insurance companies have reduced their bond holdings in favour of equity. Rather than an active reallocation of assets, this partially reflects second-round effects related to the strong equity market growth and the rise in bond

yields and corresponding decline in bond valuations against the backdrop of the ECB rate hikes in 2022 and 2023. Higher yields have also coincided in recent years with a stronger focus by banks on issuance in shorter maturities, rather than the longer maturities traditionally favoured by insurance companies. This has been particularly noteworthy for covered bonds.

Insurance companies increase equity versus debt exposures

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subordinated bank bonds continue to be treated as corporate bonds with capital charges determined by their ratings and duration, while qualifying covered bonds keep their preferential treatment. The impact of the Solvency II revisions therefore arises mainly indirectly through lower overall capital requirements, while securitisations are the only debt instruments benefiting directly through a more favourable capital treatment.

Nonetheless, certain reforms are worth highlighting for their potential impact on insurance demand for different bank bonds. Among these, the amendments relating to long-term equity

investments, securitisations and the volatility adjustment are particularly noteworthy.

1 Long-term equity investments and non-life liquidity buffers

Under Solvency II, insurance companies can classify part of their equity holdings as **long-term equity investments (LTEI)**, benefiting from a lower 22% capital charge. To qualify, these investments must be held for at least five years, be listed in the EEA or OECD, meet diversification standards and be managed under a long-term investment policy. The insurer must also be able to avoid forced s

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- Qualifying **Level 1 assets**, subject to a 0% haircut, are cash, exposures to the ECB, multilateral development banks and international organisations, and domestic currency exposures to EEA central governments and central banks.
- Qualifying **Level 2A assets**, subject to a 15% haircut, are bonds and loans rated AA- or better that are not issued by an insurance company or bank, and covered bonds rated AA- or better as referred to in Article 3(1) of the European Covered Bond Directive (CBD) (ie 'European Covered Bonds').
- Qualifying **Level 2B assets**, subject to a 25% haircut, are Simple, Transparent and Standardised (STS) securitisations (not

originated by group entities) rated AA- or better or that constitute a senior tranche; or subject to a 50% haircut, bonds and loans rated A+ to BBB- that are not issued by an insurance company or bank, and equity investments listed in the EEA or OECD, or traded on multilateral trading facilities, that are not long-term or strategic equity investments and are not investments in an insurance company or bank.

While unsecured bank bonds are excluded as eligible liquid assets, the LTEI-related liquidity buffer approach could generate some additional demand for covered bonds or STS securitisations of banks. However, we don't expect this effect to be significant given t
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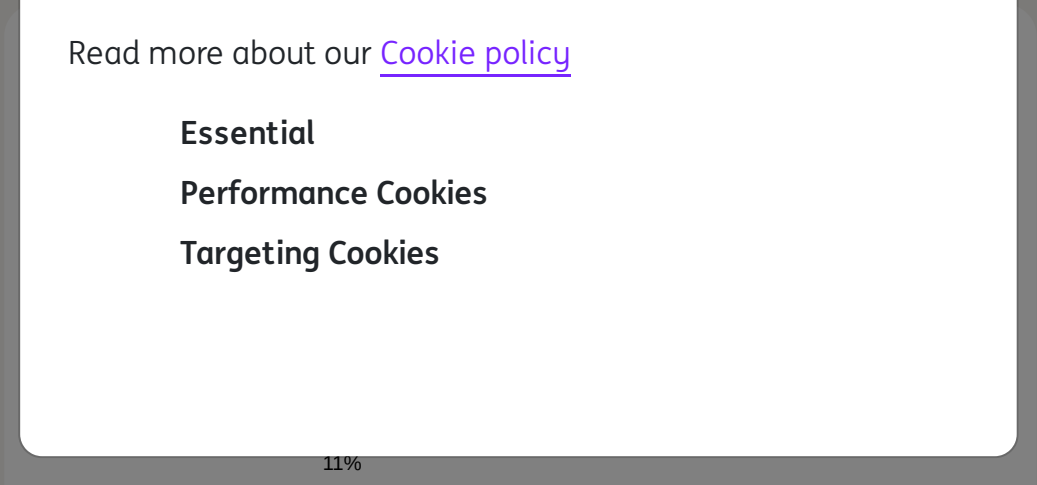

Source: EIOPA, ING

The LTEI liquidity approach is separate from the generic liquidity and concentration risk management requirements under Solvency II, as well as from the obligation under the amended Solvency II Directive to provide for a liquidity risk management plan.

❷ Lower capital requirements for securitisations

The amended Solvency II Delegated Regulation lowers the capital requirements for securitisation notes. This should encourage insurers to invest more in these transactions, helping banks to transfer risk and expand lending.

- The risk factors (a_i and b_i) for the spread risk of senior tranches of STS securitisations will become fully aligned with the treatment of similarly rated covered bonds as referred to in CBD Article 3(1).
- The risk factors for non-senior STS securitisations are reduced to a similar extent, with the new capital charges for AAA-rated non-senior notes at c.70% of the current capital charge, and for

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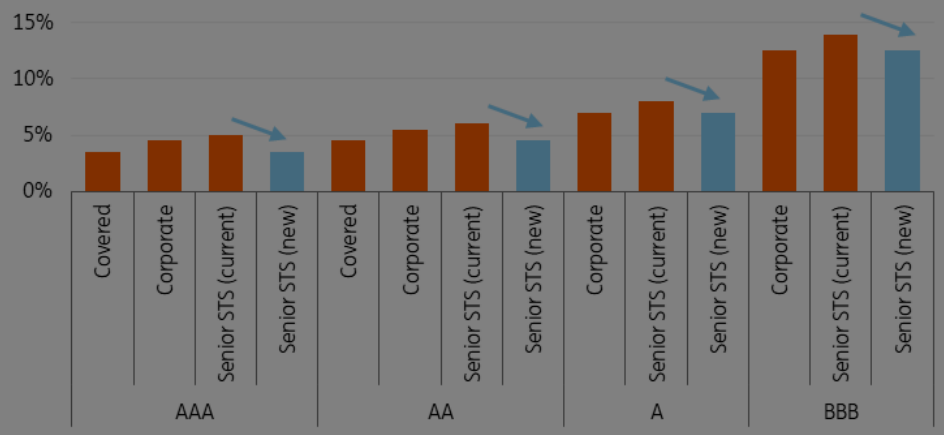
bonds. Further down the rating scale, STS securitisations will be treated closer to that of unsecured bonds from a capital perspective, where corporate and bank unsecured bonds will still benefit from a more favourable capital charge than similarly rated senior STS securitisations.

Securitisation alternatives will become more competitive from a capital perspective



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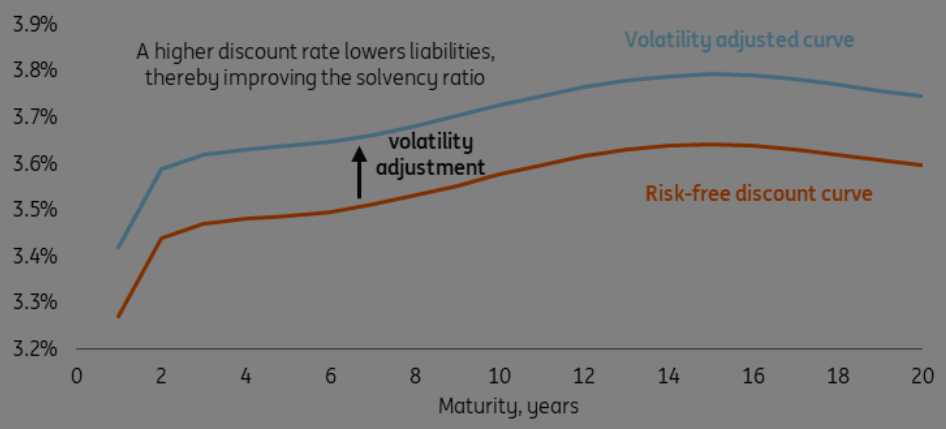
Insurance companies calculate the best estimate of their liabilities by discounting the expected future liability cash flows using the relevant risk-free interest rate term structure. To mitigate the balance sheet impact of bond spread volatility (ie, on the asset side of their balance sheet), insurance companies can discount their liabilities at the risk-free rate plus a volatility adjustment (VA).

The volatility adjustment increases the discount rate

Spot rate, %



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adjustment helps mitigate excessive widening in specific countries.

Under the current regime, the representative currency and country portfolios are constructed as uniform portfolios, even though insurers' actual fixed-income portfolios may differ substantially. Some insurers can therefore benefit excessively from the volatility adjustment if the resulting reduction in the best estimate of their liabilities exceeds the decline in the value of the relevant assets when credit spreads widen.

For this reason, the Solvency II revisions change the calculation of the volatility adjustment by a) making the applicable risk corrections (RC) more spread-sensitive, and b) introducing a credit spread sensitivity ratio (CSSR) to better align the volatility adjustment with the insurer's asset-liability profile. The latter ratio reflects the price value of a basis point of the insurer's bond, securitisation and loan investments versus the price value of a basis point of the best estimate of liabilities, with a minimum of 0 and a maximum of 1.

Moreover, subject to approval by the supervisory authority, an undertaking-specific adjustment (USA) of up to 105% may be a

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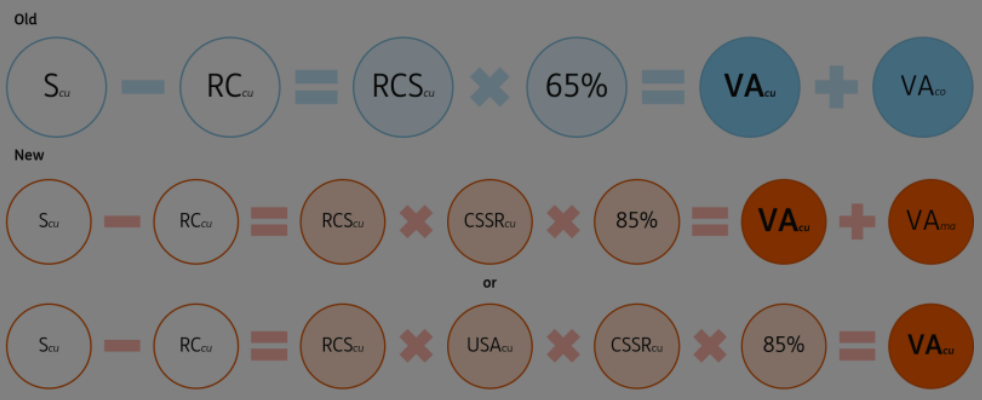
Volatility adjustment calculations



Subscripts cu = currency, co = country, ma = macro; VA = volatility adjustment, S = spread of the reference portfolio, RC = risk correction, RCS = risk-corrected spread of the reference portfolio, CSSR = credit spread sensitivity ratio, USA = undertaking-specific adjustment

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disproportionately from the volatility adjustment when their assets are less spread-sensitive than the reference portfolio.

Conclusion

The Solvency II amendments are unlikely to trigger a material reallocation in favour of bank bonds. Securitisations are the most obvious beneficiaries of a more favourable capital treatment, while covered bonds and unsecured bank bonds should mainly benefit indirectly from lower overall capital requirements for insurers. We

therefore expect the revisions to only support insurer demand for bank bonds at the margin.

Solvency II | Covered bonds | Bank Outlook 2027 | Bank bonds

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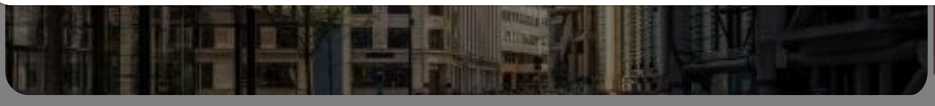

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Bank Sector Outlook 2027: High supply meets a changing financial landscape

This bundle contains 7 articles

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Upside risks to inflation and downside risks to growth clearly complicate the ECB's job. However, comments at today's press conference suggest the ECB is set to hike again in December

Carsten Brzeski

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nuanced: despite growing stagflationary pressures, the ECB still looks set to hike rates again in December.

The decision to keep interest rates unchanged was not a surprise. The main argument behind this decision is that there are currently few knock-on effects from higher headline inflation, while financing conditions, mainly bond yields, have become more restrictive.

A pause after two rate hikes this year was expected, even if macro developments since the last meeting could have justified another rate hike. Headline inflation increased again in September, and

most leading indicators point to continued resilience in the eurozone economy. However, the surge in bond yields on the back of the French crisis is already imposing a new restrictive monetary policy stance. Or in other words, the bond market has taken over the ECB's job.

According to Christine Lagarde, risks to the eurozone's growth outlook remain tilted to the downside, while risks to the inflation outlook are tilted to the upside. A combination of risks that clearly complicates the ECB's path ahead. This dilemma was underscored by her observation that key developments since the September meeting have been a further rise in energy prices and a worsening o

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1. The length and intensity of the war in the Middle East. The longer oil prices remain elevated, the higher the probability of more rate hikes.
2. The knock-on effects of higher energy prices. So far, there has hardly been any pass-through of higher energy prices in the rest of the economy. If this remains the case, the need for further rate hikes drops. If it doesn't, the possibility of rate hikes rises.
3. France. Any solution to France's current fiscal woes could bring some relief to bond markets and allow the ECB to continue hiking rates. Without any solution, bond markets have taken

over the ECB's role, making rate hikes less likely (and less needed).

With today's comments, another rate hike at the ECB's December meeting is clearly in the offing. It would require a sharp worsening of the growth outlook to probably prevent the ECB from hiking once again.

In short, with downside risks to the growth outlook and upside risks to the inflation outlook, the ECB seems to be increasingly concerned about stagflationary forces, without calling them stagflationary. Remember back in April, Lagarde called 'stagflation' a

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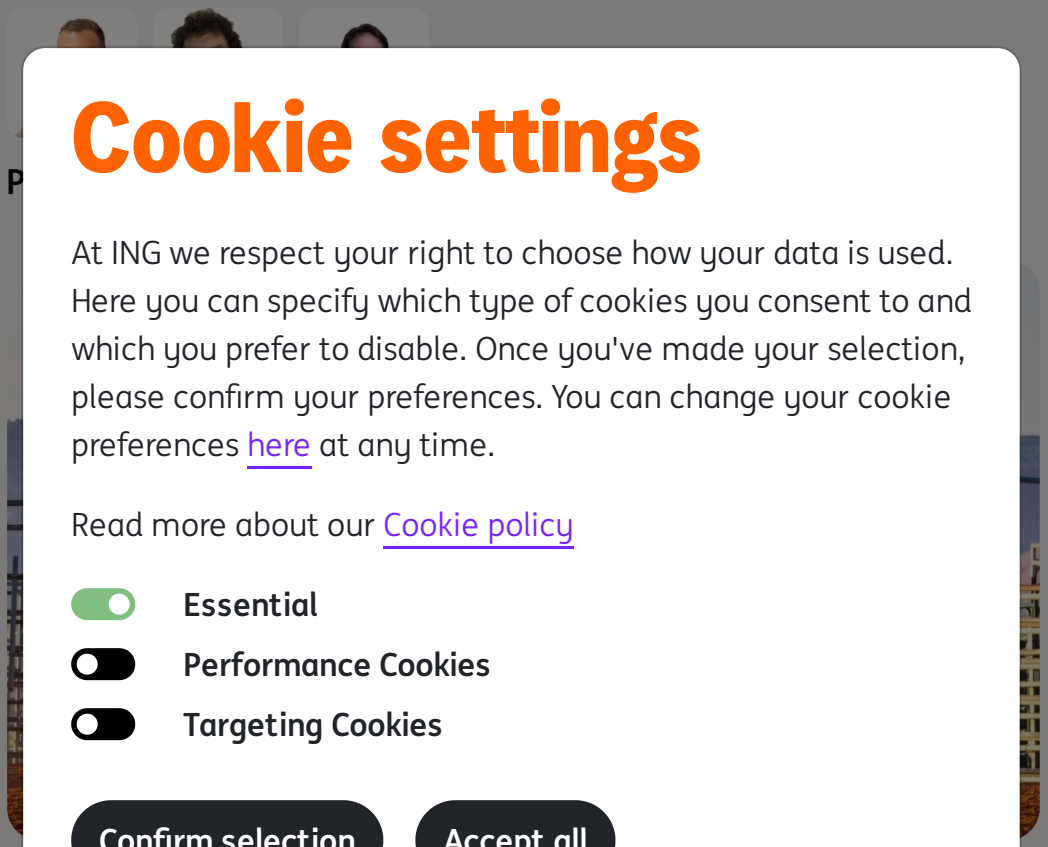
Could the US 10-year Treasury hit 6% in 2027? And could markets be too relaxed about euro rates? AI-driven growth, stubborn inflation and extraordinary government borrowing could keep global rates under pressure, while France's debt challenge adds another potential fault line in Europe. Join ING experts to explore what could drive rates in 2027



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The US 10-year Treasury hitting 6% in 2027 is not as far-fetched as it sounds. AI and productivity, extraordinary fiscal deficits, and stubborn inflation could combine to keep global rates under upward pressure. But which force will ultimately dominate? What could Treasury Secretary Bessent do if yields surge? And what if inflation proves stickier than market expectations suggest? Or is all that overblown, and we land in a less dramatic place? We explore the forces that could drive each scenario.

In the eurozone, the inflation shock may be changing rather than disappearing – is it, and if so, what are the implications? To what extent could second-round inflation pressures, heavy bond supply

and rising global real rates complicate the outlook, even if the ECB turns more dovish? Meanwhile, France's growing debt challenge adds another source of uncertainty for euro sovereign markets. How bad can this get for bond markets and rates? Will bond supply finally test investor appetite?

Join ING experts as we explore the key scenarios for US and euro rates in 2027, and where the biggest risks and opportunities lie. Sign up here.

Speakers

Padhraic Garvey, Regional Head of Research, Americas

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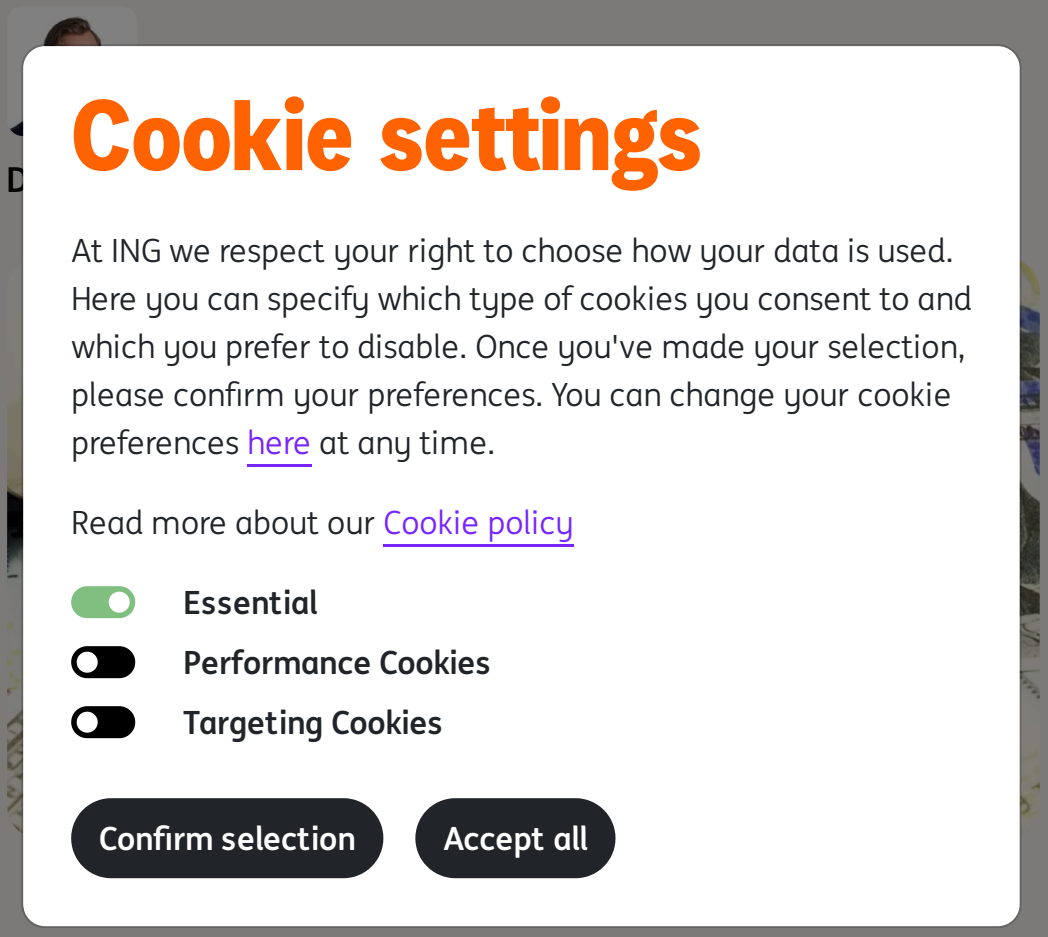
Rising fuel prices and the war with Iran have significantly increased the chances of a Democrat-controlled Congress. This could mean greater pricing pressure on pharma and more healthcare affordability measures. However, surprises do happen. We therefore assess three possible scenarios and what they mean for healthcare and pharma



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The US midterm elections take place on 3 November. All 435 seats in the House of Representatives and 35 of the 100 Senate seats are up for election. With Trump's approval rating hitting a record low according to a Fox News poll, it is no wonder that the pollsters currently suggest the Democrats lead by around 8 percentage points nationally. A Democratic takeover of Congress therefore seems most likely, but a Democratic clean sweep is not certain.

We look at what the possible outcomes could mean for healthcare and pharma.

The key differences

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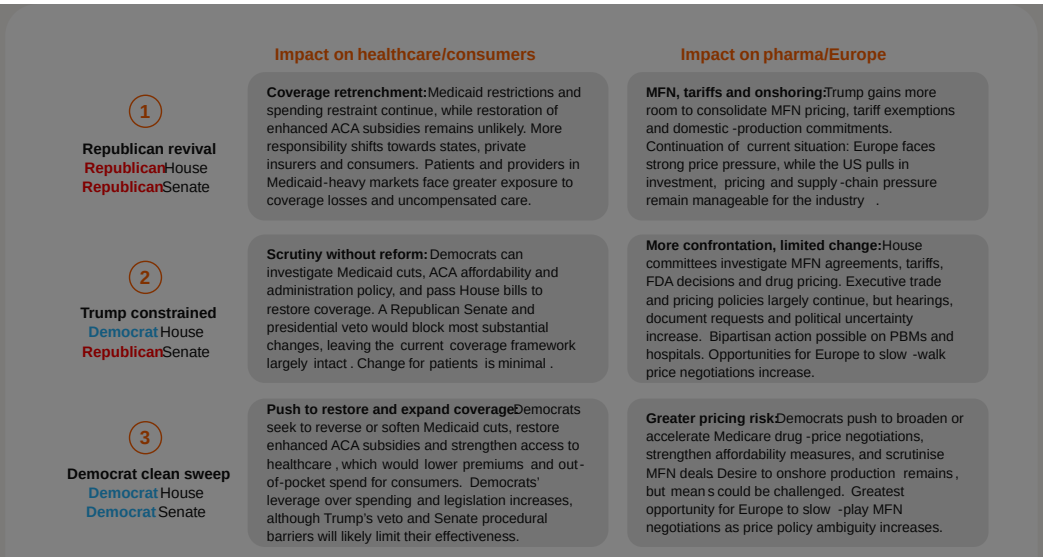
the objectives are largely bipartisan.

Midterm election scenarios and their impact on US consumers and Europe as well as healthcare and pharma



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greater scope to embed MFN pricing and use tariff exemptions and company agreements to further secure US manufacturing commitments. Pharmaceutical companies would gain greater clarity about the direction of policy, but not relief from pricing or supply-chain pressure. In short, this would be the scenario with the greatest continuity in pharma policy.

Scenario 2: Trump constrained

A Democratic House could obstruct legislation, control committees and launch investigations. But bills restoring ACA subsidies or

mitigating Medicaid cuts would face a Republican Senate and, ultimately, Trump's veto. Healthcare policy would therefore become more confrontational but not necessarily very different in practice. Coverage losses and stricter Medicaid eligibility rules would remain immediate issues, while Democrats would use hearings and must-pass spending legislation to put pressure on the administration.

Pharma would face detailed scrutiny of MFN deals, tariffs, and the implementation of Medicare negotiations. Yet neither party would control all the levers required for sweeping reform. This could create room for narrower bipartisan measures, particularly around Pharmacy Benefit Managers (PBM) and hospitals. Broader reform w… e
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w… negotiations agreed under the IRA, alongside greater scrutiny of launch prices and PBMs.

Moreover, stronger congressional protection of National Institutes of Health (NIH) funding, scientific institutions and Food and Drug Administration (FDA) review capacity would support biotech and early-stage innovation. If Democrats truly make drug-price negotiations a priority, then this scenario could lead to a mixed outcome: greater price pressure, but a stronger public research base and a better-funded FDA.

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Why a Democratic clean sweep would be good news for European governments

For Europe, pressure on the pharma industry to localise in the US will remain under all three scenarios. Democrats may criticise the means, but they also view pharmaceutical supply chains as a national-security issue. Republican and Democratic policy objectives therefore broadly align, while Trump retains substantial executive authority over trade.

The biggest difference is that a Democratic clean sweep would demand greater transparency around MFN deals and increase price p
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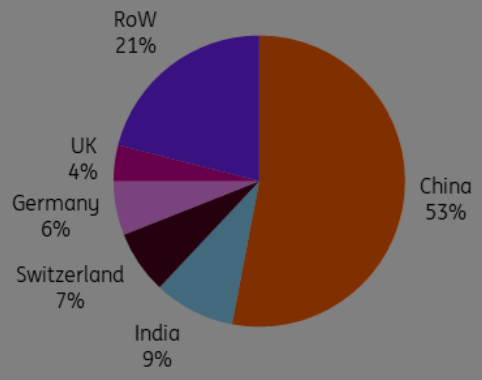
China will also keep facing bipartisan pressure. Both parties now view pharma and biotech as key to national security interests and support greater domestic manufacturing and reduced foreign dependencies. However, China's dominance in active pharmaceutical ingredients is unlikely to wane any time soon.

The US imports more than half of its pharmaceuticals from China

US pharmaceutical imports (branded and generic) by volume in 2023



Source: United Nations Commodity Trade Statistics Database; BMI; ING

Furthermore, commercial demand for Chinese innovation will not d
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